

MOTOWN SHOWDOWN

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CORE ETHICAL PRINCIPLES OF "MOTOWN SHOWDOWN"

When writing Motown Showdown, these were ethical principles I set forward for myself to try and keep the story respectful toward black Americans and to help steer myself away from harmful stereotypes. Originally, I was going to delete them from the final draft, but I think they make good guiding advice for any non-black GM or PCs who are approaching the text.

- Both cabals have sympathetic goals the players can root for. Both cabals' *intent* should be to elevate the prosperity of the marginalized over the privileged. Both cabals "want what is best" for Detroit but disagree on what that is.
- Detroit is a city that is over 80% black, and the cast and narrative should center them. At least ¾ of each cabal should be black. White players should be encouraged to play black PCs, because this can build empathy for black struggle—but they should be explicitly discouraged from doing so without sensitivity or to play up harmful stereotypes.
- None of the main characters are dealers or gangsters. (But it's okay if they recreationally use substances, as long as that isn't definitional to their personality.) Besides, being an adept... that's enough drama in your life without being in a criminal enterprise.
- None of the characters are cops or work for cops.
- All of the characters should be flawed and interesting. They can and do break the law and buck authority, but in ways that center their obsessions as adepts. They might be willing to make deals with people in power if those deals clearly benefit them, but that doesn't mean doing so is a good idea.

- Agents can enter or leave the Otherspace to anywhere in Detroit, from anywhere in Detroit, whether there is a door there or not. The Streets cannot be accessed outside of Detroit. Like the Viaturgy channel *Ghost Roads*, anyone who sees an Agent suddenly appear will not notice or even care as long as they appear somewhere they could sensibly be.

AGENT: DIANE WILSON

An elderly woman with a wavy bob and a bright red dress, she purports to be a dabbler in the occult underground who deals in vintage hardware and fixtures for historic buildings. Diane Wilson is actually a resident of the *Streets of Motown* and one of their agents. (She does sell vintage hardware, though. She lives in a very convenient place to make a living of that!)

- **Wound Threshold:** 50
- **Noble Stimulus:** Protect Detroit and the Streets of Motown
- **Rage Stimulus:** Threatening the Streets of Motown or the city of Detroit
- **Fear Stimulus:** The destruction of Detroit, physically or metaphysically
- **Agent of Motown:** 35%. Subs for: Knowledge. Protects Shocks: Unnatural. Coerces: Unnatural.
- **Urbanomancy (obsession):** 65%. Casts Rituals, Gutter Magick.
- **Viaturgy (obsession):** 40%.
- Diane has the ongoing madness ***Delusion***. She believes that the act of protecting Detroit as a lifelong Agent will bring about a national program of black reparations.

If the urbanomancer successfully passes the room's challenge, they gain Viaturgy at 15% in *addition* to any existing skill they have at urbanomancy, and they gain the new obsession: *Protect Detroit and the Streets of Motown*. Losing their old obsession and gaining a new one is a *Self 9* check. The player can only flip-flop adept rolls related to their new obsession, irrespective of school. They must also take one ongoing madness if they haven't already (see pp26 of *Book 1: Play*), a toxic coping mechanism they use to deal with the trauma of holding two conflicting adept schools in their head.

AGENTS

Passing the Room's challenge will emblazon the newly minted Agent with the seal of Detroit over their heart, but the two feminine Greco-Roman figures are replaced by Aretha Franklin and Diana Ross in resplendent red gowns.

After becoming an Agent of the Streets of Motown, the Agent has the following powers and restrictions:

- They can use both the schools of *Viaturgy* and *Urbanomancy* by using each school's charging structure. Note that **both** schools are limited to working within the city of Detroit and the associated Motown Otherspace, not just Urbanomancy.
- They gain the new obsession: *Protect Detroit and the Streets of Motown*. The player can only flip-flop adept rolls related to their new obsession, irrespective of school.
- Once the Adept becomes an agent of the room, their taboo is that they cannot leave the Detroit metro or drive a car assembled outside of Michigan. Doing so immediately drains them of all charges.
- They can help a cabal pursue any agenda which will increase the power and standing of Detroit in exchange for 3 charges and the cabal offering a Detroit viaturge or urbanomancer to the Streets of Motown. The cabalmate must then undergo the room's Renunciation.

THE TWO CABALS

Before beginning the module, the GM must select one of the two cabal story tracks to run. The members of the other cabal will become rival GMCs to the Player Characters; a pesky thorn in their sides whose goals are intrinsically antithetical to theirs just by the nature of their adept obsession. I recommend printing out the full list of formulas for Viaturges and Urbanomancers and placing them on the table for players to peruse if possible, as this allows them to use their full list of formulas and not just the ones on their sheets. Viaturge rules are page 167 of Book 1. The rules for Urbanomancers can be found in Book 5:Mine, on page 35.

You may wish to allow your players to choose which of the two cabals, but if you allow this, I recommend doing it well ahead of time or your players may spend an hour debating whether or not cars should be banned, or, alternately, which era of American muscle car was the greatest, and never get around to choosing a side.

VIATURGES

OBJECTIVE: Build a Detroit auto industry owned and run by local mechanics & drag racers.

The Viaturge cabal, the **Motown Breakers**, consists of former and current drag racers mostly from the suburbs and working-class neighborhoods of Detroit.

THE BIG THREE

In our fake version of Detroit, there are three major car companies, known as "The Big Three." Their names are:

DRAFT MOTOR CO - An American auto company founded in Detroit itself, whose assembly plant was once in Detroit proper. A radical black labor formation, the Draft Revolutionary Union Movement, or DRUM, organized in the plant during the 1970s. It was sold to Universal Motors in the 1980s, demolished, and rebuilt.

UNIVERSAL MOTORS - The largest auto-manufacturer. Famous for their trucks, but they make everything from sedans to trains.

BRYANT MOTORS - Founded in the suburbs of Detroit, Bryant Motors pioneered the idea that a car should be within the financial reach of the American worker.

Any resemblance to real auto-companies is purely coincidental.

KENYA YOUNG

Kenya Young grew up in her teens and early twenties driving illegal drag races over by Fortress Burger on the East Side of Detroit. It was a dizzy, crazy time in her youth that she's never quite quit, but she's turned in her headiest days for her commitment to Resurrection Auto, her mechanics shop where she electrifies classic muscle cars. The specialty work has kept her shop alive while a lot of other mechanics in Detroit have struggled over the years, but it makes Kenya's blood boil knowing cheap labor and bad design is making the premiere American electric car right now--the Henrietta. Kenya wants Motown to be the center of the new, clean motor culture more than anything.

Kenya cast *Rolling Throne* on her beloved '76 Goblin, Dave, back in her Fortress Burger days and has totally electrified him over the years. Dave is a stubborn old man and demands premium batteries or he starts to knock and rattle. In addition, Kenya can only gain minor charges in Dave and driving another car breaks taboo (good thing she gets her assistants to test drive most of her stock these days.)

The room can and will put the recruit into situations that challenge their commitment to Detroit over Viaturgy which will cause additional *self* and *helplessness* checks.

If the Viaturge successfully passes the room's challenge, they gain urbanomancy at 15% in *addition* to any existing skill they have at viaturgy, and they gain the new obsession: *Protect Detroit and the Streets of Motown*. Losing their old obsession and gaining a new one is a *Self 9* check. The player can only flip-flop adept rolls related to their new obsession, irrespective of school. They must also take one ongoing madness if they haven't already (see pp26 of *Book 1: Play*), a toxic coping mechanism they use to deal with the trauma of holding two conflicting adept schools in their head.

TRIAL OF RENUNCIATION: URBANOMANCER

The Urbanomancer finds themselves in the Streets of Motown, driving a car, a few miles from the nearest exit on the I-96/Rosa Parks Memorial Highway. A green interstate sign in front of them instructs the urbanomancer:

ONLY 3 100 MILE MARATHONS TO GO AND 330 NIGHTS IN A STRANGE PLACE BEFORE <PLAYER'S NAME> IS RETURNED TO DETROIT.

The urbanomancer must then begin accruing 3 minor charges and 330 significant charges in viaturgy. Every time they successfully generate a minor or significant charge, the number on the sign, which appears every time they enter the Detroit interstate system, decreases. Breaking the Viaturgy taboo causes a *helplessness 4* check. Breaking their Urbanomancer taboo causes a *self 5* check. If gaining a charge in viaturgy causes them to hurt the fabric of Detroit street life or street culture, it is a *self 6* check. What that means should be somewhat up to interpretation by the GM and, to a lesser extent, the player.

The room can and will put the recruit into situations that challenge their commitment to Detroit--in particular the automotive-based parts of Detroit culture--over urbanomancy which will cause additional *self* and *helplessness* checks.

Streets of Motown; they may think they've found their way in the city only to turn a corner and end up in the middle of Brightmoor. One street is always affixed in space, however; Woodward Ave, the cultural and spatial center of Detroit. Woodward itself always reflects its current appearance, and this is where Agents live. At the foot of Woodward Ave, the famous *Spirit of Detroit* statue appears as a famous Motown musician wearing a red suit or dress with red wings.

The Agents are the only actual humans alive in The Streets of Motown; real humans may appear as transient, revenant-like figures who characters can grill for basic information about the city, but that information will reflect the location and time of the building in real-life Detroit, not in the Streets of Motown.

RENUNCIATION

Only Urbanomancers or Viaturges are able to enter The Streets of Motown. The Renunciation changes based on whether the participant is an Urbanomancer or a Viaturge.

TRIAL OF RENUNCIATION: VIATURGE

The Viaturge appears in the Streets of Motown in front of a historic marker. The marker instructs the Viaturge that they have

ONLY 300 HOURS OF DETROIT CONTEMPLATION AND 33 CITY EVENTS TO GO BEFORE <PLAYER'S NAME> IS RETURNED TO DETROIT.

The viaturge then must begin accruing 75 minor charges and 33 significant charges in urbanomancy. Every time they successfully generate a minor or significant charge, the number on the sign, which moves to stand outside any building they stand in front of, decreases. Breaking the Urbanomancer taboo causes a *helplessness 4* check. Breaking their Viaturgy taboo causes a *self 5* check. If gaining a charge in urbanomancy causes them to hurt cars or automobile culture in a material way, it is a *self 6* check. What that means should be somewhat up to interpretation by the GM and, to a lesser extent, the player.

Finally, if Dave is damaged, she can't get any more charges until he's repaired. In exchange, driving Dave gives Kenya quite a few benefits:

- Kenya can flip-flop all "Pursuit" rolls.
- Kenya can sub Viaturgy for "Pursuit."
- Dave won't start without Kenya's express permission, or unless the driver has a relationship with her of 25% or higher.
- You always have a great parking spot unless it's literally impossible.
- Trunk space mystically doubles, which is pretty handy on a tiny Goblin.
- If you spend a significant charge, Dave will return to Kenya five miles above the speed limit, obeying all traffic signals and succeeding at any task that would prompt a "Pursuit" roll. It drives toward Kenya until it reaches her or as many miles as is equal to the result of the casting roll.

LATOYA MURPHY

Latoya's dad worked a steady job at the nearby Universal Motors factory and taught her to love the trucks he helped build during his day job. He finally achieved the American dream in the early naughts and bought a home in suburban Eastpointe, north of Detroit--only to lose it all during a round of layoffs and the foreclosure crisis. These days Latoya uses her magick to help her get by as a rideshare driver on taxicab apps, but Latoya never forgot the unfairness of what happened to her father or love of trucks he nurtured in her. More than anything, she wants a Motown that honors the workers who build the cars that come off the assembly line--a Motown by and for people like her dad.

Latoya owns a souped-up 2011 Universal Motors Yosemite four-door pickup truck.

JAHID SARKAR

Jahid's parents left Bangladesh in the early eighties, when he was a toddler--he grew up in the working-class town of Hamtramck, volunteering with the imam at his mosque and running a mechanic shop along with his dad, Shourav. After scripping

and saving, Jahid managed to save up enough money to buy a place of his own, and for a while he lived the dream: white picket fence, beautiful wife, adorable kid. Then he lost his home in the foreclosure crisis when the shop went through a rough patch. Too proud to move in with his parents, he squatted various abandoned properties all over Detroit from night to night. That experience caused his wife to leave him and take primary custody of his kid, but he did gain one thing from it; the ability to channel the car magick of viaturgy. Now he's working with his cabal to try and renew his belief that hard work and community ties can bring you prosperity and stability.

Jahid owns a former police car, a fixed-up 2007 Draft Catalyst he painted silver. It's what's known by car guys as a "sleeper"---a souped up ride that looks like an ordinary vehicle if you aren't looking too closely. Because of this---and his radar detector---Jahid often does work for the cabal that needs to be a little more on the down-low.

Jahid starts the game with a relationship slot occupied by his kid, Eva. Which slot is up to you.

NADIA MOORE

Nadia Moore hit puberty and realized they was going to grow up living on the edge whether they liked it or not. Black, poor, and non-binary, Nadia is not willing to give up on living their truth. Growing up near Fortress Burger on Woodward Ave, they'd walk over to watch the cars zoom by and became an unwitting fan and apprentice of Detroit street racing culture. After scrimping and saving from working part-time at *Mike's Old School Kicks*, a shoe store and Detroit hip-hop venue, Nadia combined their love of hip-hop, Detroit, and car tuning into a 2016 Bryant Rivet *Itasha*, a souped-up compact car with elaborate decals of their favorite character from the anime *RyuKyu X*, Fahita. Since tuning the Rivet, Nadia makes most of their money winning street races. Nadia tries not to think about the future too much, but knows they won't be able to live off racing forever.

They've also tried to rap at a few open mics. Their reception was not good.

ROOM OF RENUNCIATION: THE STREETS OF MOTOWN

AGENDA

The Streets of Motown is a Room of Renunciation with an extremely specific and singular purpose; it takes denizens of the Detroit metro who are either viaturges or urbanomancers and turns them into Agents of The Streets of Motown---both the Otherspace, which is a magical reflection of the inner psyche of Detroit, and the actual real-life city of Detroit. The Room sends denizens of Detroit who are a member of one adept school and forces them to accrue charges in the manner of the other school until they understand *both* viaturgy and urbanomancy. This process will mentally destroy them, and also, the room hopes, turn them into an Agent.

Some Agents affectionately refer to the Streets as "The Spirit of Detroit", and its goal is to force viaturges and urbanomancers of Motown to recognize the importance of each other's school to Detroit. Most Urbanomancers resent the existence and presence of cars, seeing them as dangerous, polluting luxury items that negatively impact the streetscape with parking, freeways, and lessened pedestrian access. Viaturges, meanwhile, even while enjoying Motor City's history and automotive culture, resent the traffic, inconvenience and limitations of a dense, gridded streetscape on their ability to move quickly through the city (at least without burning up a few charges.) It is the goal of the Streets of Motown to teach urbanomancers you can't take the Motor out of Motor City---and viaturges you can't take the City out of Motor City.

APPEARANCE

The Streets of Motown appears as a maze-like, tetris configuration and reconfiguration of the Detroit metro. Streets and buildings randomly array and re-array themselves in time and space, appearing as Ford's historic 1892 workshop one moment, then the opulent Michigan Theater of the 1920s, then resolving itself to the modern-day Michigan Building and parking garage. The street it's on will change from Bagley to Temple to Henry and back. The Streets of Motown appear endlessly familiar and hopelessly strange to residents of Detroit who end up in the

- **Urbanomancy (obsession):** 35%. Casts Rituals, Gutter Magick. Lesser Magi.

LEON

Leon is a sometime dabbler in the occult underground with a red Morita tuner emblazoned with a vinyl decal from the anime *Boku no Super School*. He is a frequenter of Detroit's rap scene (just a fan, not a performer).

Leon is eager to learn how to become a viaturge. He is probably willing to do risky tasks to that end for the Motown Breakers, if they can successfully *Connect* with him or intend to make good on the promise to teach Leon viaturgy. He cannot, however, become the scion--he's not a viaturge yet!

- **Wound Threshold:** 50
- **Noble Stimulus:** Treating a lady right
- **Rage Stimulus:** Dissing someone for their passions
- **Fear Stimulus:** Never amounting to anything
- **Scene Kid:** 65%. Substitutes for: Status, Subs for: Knowledge, Protects Shocks Against: Isolation

You can assume most of Leon's upbeat abilities are around 50% and his downbeat abilities are around 30%.

BEAT COPS

- **Beat Cop:** 50% Subs for Pursuit, Provides Firearm Attacks, Subs for Struggle

SHERIFF & LOCAL COPS			
Shock Meter	Hardened	Failed	Abilities
Helplessness	3	1	Fitness 50%
Isolation	2	0	Status 55%
Self	5	2	Knowledge 40%
Unnatural	2	0	Notice 55%
Violence	4	2	Connect 45%
			Struggle 35%

URBANOMANCERS

The **Block Busters**, an urbanomancer cabal named after the racist housing practice (see pp11), hail from a combination of the upcoming Detroit neighborhoods of Midtown and Corktown (the Ward Heelers), and the comparatively poorer neighborhoods of North End and Brightmoor (The Street Rats).

OBJECTIVE: Use Detroit to become the center of a train revival in the United States, this time owned and run by working-class Detroiters.

Alternate taboo for urbanomancers (Street Rats): *Street Rats only can take of the bounty that the city gives them freely. Street rats must procure all things necessary for their survival from the city for free--food, clothes, and shelter. If a street rat builds a tiny house from repurposed materials, that's within their taboo; buying a mini-house and parking it on the street is not. Dumpster diving or growing produce in an urban garden is okay. Food, clothes or shelter bought with pan-handled money violates taboo, as begging is a way of earning money. Most street rats scavenge food, clothes, and the odds and ends they need to survive out of dumpsters--or their cabal...*

LEE SHERMAN

Lee Sherman used to own a beautiful family hardware store in Brightmoor that was his pride and joy. Once the foreclosure crisis hit, he lost his customers and then his store in Brightmoor when the poverty that gripped the neighborhood worsened. Now rich investors are snapping up abandoned and foreclosed properties and leaving them to rot until they smell profit--including his old store.

Lee took what was left of his stock after auction and built himself a tiny house at the edge of an abandoned lot, in view of his old place. He wandered the streets until they became his friends and then his accomplices as he learned to channel urbanomancy. The city may have abandoned him but he never abandoned the city. Now he wants to make sure that the future of Detroit doesn't turn its back on the people who live here.

DARIUS ANDERSON

Darius grew up in the sleepy suburb of Dearborn with two parents who were proud to have "made it" by getting out of Motor City. Darius, however, thumbed his nose at their sacrifice, sneaking out in their car to enjoy the vibrant street life of Downtown Detroit. He spent his nights at *Mike's Old School Kicks*, becoming an avid fan of the Detroit underground hip-hop scene and the street culture of Detroit. Once he graduated high school, he shipped off to college at the University of Ann Arbor to pursue a degree in urban planning and live the authentic city life he craved. When he came back to work at the Detroit Transit Agency, he was expecting to be a big damn hero after he helped get the funding for the Detroit City Mover, a beautiful streetcar that ran through the heart of Detroit. But instead of a hero's welcome he watched the city rebel in wave after wave of protests. The Mover stopped just short of the North End, right where poor Detroiters needed it most--and they cut the North End's bus line to pay for it. Darius vowed to make it up to the city he wronged and listen to the will of the streets he betrayed. He kept his job at the transit authority to help Detroit on and off the clock; In return, the city gave him the power of urbanomancy to right his wrongs and create a Detroit that listens to the people.

LATISHA SMITH

Latisha Smith stayed in a bad marriage three years too long because it meant a roof over her head and three square meals a day. She started to spend more and more time outside her home to escape what she felt and heard inside it, and took up gardening at Greentown Urban Gardens, a community garden nearby. While out tending her beefsteak tomatoes, she got a text from her husband that made her dread the journey home more than ever. She decided to spend the night in the garden shed. Then she spent another, and another... and never ended up going back. The city provides better for Latisha than her husband ever did--and it never asks for anything back. Now she protects it in turn--along with any other lost souls she finds there.

LYDIA GAUTHIER

A tall woman with a narrow frame and short, finger waved hair, Lydia Gauthier works for Bryant Motor Company's transit and engineering division, designing trains and buses for American urban centers. She started out as a bus mechanic for The Detroit Transit agency and worked her way through sheer determination and raw charisma into a much better gig. Lydia is an urbanomancer and what's known as a Lesser Magi--an Adept who no longer seriously practices their magick and has fallen "off the wagon."

Lydia's parents immigrated to Detroit from Haiti and made sure she kept her nose clean and worked hard. She was intensely proud to be a part of the urban infrastructure for the cities of the future--cleaner, safer, more accessible cities with real transit and good-paying jobs. This last month, Bryant Motors came to her door demanding he fulfill an obscure clause in her engineering gig; that if ever called upon to do so by Bryant Motors, she would move to the Streets of Motown in exchange for a generous bonus and double her salary. Thinking at the time she signed she already lived in Detroit and it wasn't much of a sacrifice, Lydia put it out of her mind only to find he was being tapped to sacrifice herself to a magical otherspace from which she might never return. Her goal, if she made it through the Trial of the Streets, was to craft a Motown friendly to the continued existence and agenda of the Big Three American Automobile manufacturers above all else, ensuring that their machinery was baked into any New Urbanism that emerged out of the streets. If she betrayed or failed in her duty, Bryant Motors would cut off her salary and make sure Feds became very interested in making her parents' life difficult.

- **Wound Threshold:** 50
- **Noble Stimulus:** Help build the New Urbanism
- **Rage Stimulus:** Car-centered infrastructure
- **Fear Stimulus:** Stabbing her community in the back
- **Transit Engineer:** 60%. Substitutes for: Knowledge, Subs for: Notice, Protects Shocks Against: Isolation

TRACY GATES

A medium-built man with a shaved head and a distant expression, He is the owner of a local Detroit Draft Cars dealership who worked his way into the position as a former certified Draft Mechanic. Tracy is a Viaturge, but what's known as a Lesser Magi; an Adept who has essentially fallen off the wagon and lives a more-or-less normal life while collecting occasional minor viaturgy charges and doing casual magick.

Tracy Gates grew up in a rough neighborhood in the North End, got a job as a mechanic, and through pure blood, sweat, and tears, managed to make it as a dealership owner. He breathed a sigh of relief during the auto bailout and managed to hang on through the hard times. This last month, Draft Motors came to his door demanding he fulfill an obscure clause in his franchise contract; that if ever called upon to do so by Draft Motors, he would move to the Streets of Motown in exchange for a generous bonus and guaranteed salary, regardless of the health of his dealership. Thinking at the time he signed he already lived in Detroit and it wasn't much of a sacrifice, Tracy put it out of his mind only to find he was being tapped to sacrifice himself to a magical otherspace from which he might never return. His goal, if he made it through the Trial of the Streets, was to craft a Motown friendly to the continued existence and agenda of the Big Three American Automobile manufacturers above all else. If he betrayed or failed in his duty, Draft motors would cut off his salary, bankrupt his dealership and make sure his family did not see a dime.

- **Wound Threshold:** 50
- **Noble Stimulus:** Protect his family
- **Rage Stimulus:** Buying foreign autos
- **Fear Stimulus:** Family being thrown on the streets
- **Dealership Owner:** 60%. Substitutes for: Lie, Subs for: Connect, Coerces: Isolation
- **Viaturgy (obsession):** 35%. Casts Rituals, Gutter Magick. Lesser Magi.

RACHEL BERNSTEIN

Rachel grew up in the picturesque suburbs of West Bloomfield in a good Jewish family and went to the University of Ann Arbor on a full scholarship. Once she got out, she told her parents the truth--she had been assigned the wrong gender at birth. They did not take it well, and so Rachel moved to the city where she got a job with "Heritage Alive," a nonprofit that turns historic Detroit homes and buildings into affordable housing. It was while working there that she learned about the Detroit area's ugly legacy of redlining, gentrification, blockbusting, and sundown communities. Re-dedicating herself as a Detroiter for life, Rachel sees her role now as a protector and activist-citizen of the city; someone who vows to use her newfound supernatural connection with the city to make it a better place for the people who live here.

RACIST HOUSING & URBAN POLICIES

Let's just go down the list, I guess? Brace yourself for some racist horseshit.

REDLINING

The practice of deliberately denying aid and public goods and services to predominately poor & minority (usually black) neighborhoods. Sometimes red-lined neighborhoods were demolished to make interstate highways, as was the case with Black Bottom in Detroit.

BLOCK-BUSTING

Flipping houses by telling white landowners that black americans will be moving into their neighborhoods to get them to sell their property below its value, then selling it to a black family at a higher price. The Block Busters are named after this practice as a "fuck you" to the (continued) legacy of racist housing policy in Detroit.

SUNDOWN COMMUNITIES

White suburbs where black americans were not allowed after sundown, hence the name. Dearborn was once a sundown community.

GENTRIFICATION

The process whereby real estate investors inflate the cost of housing stock and apartments in downtown areas when they believe those areas have become desirable, centralized neighborhoods. Sometimes rent is just jacked up to match what landlords think they can get; other times, mass evictions take place in order to flip the property the land is on and turn worn, lower-cost multi-family buildings into tall, expensive condo buildings of mostly 1-room studios.

GETTING INTO CHARACTER

MOTOWN BREAKERS

1. Tell your players to select a character from the sheets put in front of them. If you have not already, make sure to review the [ETHICAL PRINCIPLES](#) (pp04).
2. Your cabal are *Viaturges*; people who are so obsessed with the American automobile that you can use cars to *channel magick*. Read the character description attached to your sheet, then look briefly through your sheet to familiarize yourself with your powers and identities. Feel free to tweak your character as long as their core identities and passions still make sense. Have each player say a sentence or two about their character and their background.
3. Your cabal has been meeting in Detroit near the Fortress Burger for years now, but you share a common dream; a Motown automotive industry run by and for Detroiters, not huge conglomerates fleeing workers, mechanics, and the people of Detroit in a race to the bottom.
4. Pick a *relationship* role for the Cabal, putting the same percentile that corresponds to the stat beneath the role. This is how you see your cabal-mates as a whole; if you feel like you need to take care of them, for example, they're your *responsibility*. If you look up to them, they're your *mentors*. Have each player say a sentence or two about why they have that relationship with the cabal.
5. Pick a *relationship* role for one other character, putting the same percentile that corresponds to the ability rating beneath the role. This is the kind of relationship you have with that character. Have each player say a sentence or two about which cabal-mate they have a relationship with and why.

- **The Salesman (obsession):** 68%. Casts Rituals, Gutter Magick

Thomas Campbell				
Shock Meter	Hardened	Failed	Abilities	
Helplessness	2	0	Fitness 55%	Dodge 25%
Isolation	5	3	Status 40%	Pursuit 40%
Self	4	2	Knowledge 45%	Lie 35%
Unnatural	3	0	Notice 50%	Secrecy 30%
Violence	3	0	Connect 50%	Struggle 30%

Here are The Salesman's channels. More detail can be found in *Book 5: Mine* on page 66.

The Salesman
1-50%: A successful avatar roll means the Salesman can get a good deal on something, either buying or selling. Resisting is a rank 3 Self or rank 3 Unnatural check.
51-70%: The Salesman can trade intangibles with a successful roll. He can trade Failed Notches for hardened; wound threshold for identity percentiles; relationships for objective points. The contract is only valid for willing and knowledgeable participants; coercion and the first channel don't work. Trickery cannot be involved. Make sure any effects are described in game and not just mechanically; trading away a relationship forces the object to believe a slight has occurred, but the imagined slight perhaps helped push your objective forward.

over there instead, because there's a rumor they're thinking of building affordable housing in the garden and they don't know how the new owners will feel about food gardens on their land.

NO GO

If the players do not succeed, the camera pans up on the city of Detroit. Day in, day out, things as they ever were; the players consider the deal now and again, but don't know that they're prepared to pay the price. Things in Detroit may change, but it's not clear that they're better. In this city, there's no shortcuts.

LOST TO THE ROOM...

Two years later, the players briefly see the cabal mate they lost to the street. Just as they begin to approach them, they are gone again.

APPENDIX

THOMAS CAMPBELL

Thomas Campbell is a tall, aggressively bland white man with a crew cut and a blue suit. He is an attache and finance guy at Universal Motor Company who keeps an eye on supernatural activities in and around Detroit, particularly those that may impact the UMC.

He is also an avatar of the Salesman; a very good one, who specializes in making deals that get flies out of UMC's face and turn them into assets.

- **Wound Threshold:** 50
- **Noble Stimulus:** Make Detroit the Paris of the West
- **Rage Stimulus:** Being told he only cares about money
- **Fear Stimulus:** UMC has no loyalty to me (isolation)
- **Company Man:** 50%. Substitutes for: Lie, Resists Shocks: Self, Subs for: Status

6. All of your characters are, or were at one time, poor. What was the absolutely worst night you spent in your car, and why? Some ideas if players are having trouble:

- You had to eat something really disgusting, but "probably" safe, from a dumpster to keep from being hungry.
- You were surveilled or harassed by the police.
- Someone scary followed you and your vialurgy powers got you out of it.
- You had to call on a favor from someone you promised you would never ask for help from again.

BLOCK BUSTERS

1. Tell your players to select a character from the sheets put in front of them. If you have not already, make sure to review the [ETHICAL PRINCIPLES](#) (pp04).
2. Your cabal are *Urbanomancers*: people who are so obsessed with the city you live in that you can use it to *channel magick*. You've blurred the line between your adept magick and your vision of Detroit's future to the point where you aren't even sure where one ends and the other begins. Read the character description attached to your sheet, then look briefly through your sheet to familiarize yourself with your powers and identities. Feel free to tweak your character as long as their core identities and passions still make sense. Have each player say a sentence or two about their character and their background.
3. Your cabal has been meeting in Detroit in the parking garage of the Michigan Building for years now, building toward a common vision; revive Michigan Central Station into a major train depot and make Detroit *the Paris of the*

West once more, a world-class city by and for Detroiters instead for rich industrialists to profit off.

4. Pick a *relationship* role for the Cabal, putting the same percentile that corresponds to the stat beneath the role. This is how you see your cabal-mates as a whole; if you feel like you need to take care of them, for example, they're your *responsibility*. If you look up to them, they're your *mentors*.
5. Pick a *relationship* role for one other character, putting the same percentile that corresponds to the ability rating beneath the role. This is the kind of relationship you have with that character. Have each player say a sentence or two about which cabal-mate they have a relationship with and why.
6. At some point in your character's life, they either *felt* homeless or *were* homeless, literally. How did your connection to Detroit make you feel like it's home? Here are some examples if the players are having trouble:
 - You met someone here who changed your life and you see them as emblematic of the city. Because of them, this is home now.
 - You saw something in the city--a mural, a restaurant--that inspired you at your absolute nadir and reminded you why life was worth living.
 - You had a truly transcendent moment at an event--a concert, a market--that made you realize you belonged here.
 - A group in Detroit--in addition to your cabal, perhaps before you met them--functioned as a "found family" when your "real" family let you down.

SUMMARY

Detroit is *your city*. Your cabal would do anything for her. Cut down anyone that crosses her. And you're dedicated to bringing her back to her former glory the only way you know how: *Magick*. With a little time and a lot of sacrifice, you can make a

Nadia would be a great set of hands to help keep the business going while she pursues expanding it.

Jahid is leaving a house and his wife and kid are standing in front of his Catalyst.

...WITH A DEAL

If the players succeeded using Thomas Campbell's offer, Kenya's email comes from Universal Motors. Nadia and Latoya are offered a job at the UM Assembly plant instead of Resurrection Auto (unless, of course, Kenya offers them a job on her own initiative), and Latoya does not receive a call from Black Detroit Matters. Jahid's parents are in front of his car instead of his wife and child.

BUSTERS: OUR STREETS

THEY DID IT

Latisha receives a call on her cell phone from Black Detroit Matters. They have a promising young candidate for mayor passionate about Urban Policy, and they're looking for someone who knows a lot about transit and could help create great policy for the city. Does she know anyone?

Rachel is at work one day at Detroit Heritage Alive and a co-worker comes up to her. There's talk of demolishing the 375 and turning it into housing again--organizations in the city are banding together to make sure housing policy in the former Black Bottom is just. Just as she's sitting down at her desk, she sees paperwork that shows that Heritage Alive has bought the old Sherman Hardware building in Brightmoor and is working with another non-profit in the city to lease the first floor property to a Detroit Entrepreneur who needs a leg up.

...WITH A DEAL

Darius receives a call directly, and the promising young candidate is instead recruited by YIMBY Detroit, a non-profit in favor of making "people-first" cities. Rachel finds out her business is receiving a grant to turn abandoned housing whose property is used by Greenwood Urban Gardens into affordable homes. Latisha is approached by Greenwood Urban Gardens staff, who are thinking of opening a new garden in Brightmoor near Lee's shed--they're wondering if she'd like to help out

THIRD OPTIONS & KARMA HOUDINIS

Okay, but *is it* possible for a player to become scion without killing their shadow?

Never say never, but for this to happen, the player needs to *trick* the room somehow. There are almost certainly ways to trick magical otherspaces using formulas or gutter magick to lie about how dead you/your opponent are or force the room to give up its secrets. But that's not playing by the Room's rules, so it has to be good. It has to be clever. Not just any checker can get away with that kind of shit.

5. EPILOGUE: SAME SHIT, DIFFERENT

DAY

For the final scene, any player that entered the blue door should be shown the RENUNCIATION (pp70). If you're playing this as a one-shot, opening the door is the last time the player has control of their PC.

For the remaining players, ask them what they do when/if their cabalmates never arrive, and how they cope with their loss over the coming days. Then cut to some time later. We see the scenes of Detroit; people milling around Downtown, Midtown Bistros, Eastern Market's hustle and bustle in the warming days, street races and car chases among the drag racers of the city as the Mosques of Hamtramck and Churches of North End bells' ring.

BREAKERS: MOTOR CITY NEVER DIES

THEY DID IT

A week after the events of the game, Latoya receives a call from Black Detroit Matters. They are asking her to consider a run for mayor.

Kenya receives an email at Resurrection Auto from the National Black Business Association, suggesting she pursue Series A funding for a mass-produced electric car based on the cars she's electrified at Resurrection Auto. It occurs to Kenya that

Detroit that works for her people instead of for the fat cats that try to carve her up like a turkey.

There's just one problem--a bunch of dumbass rival wizards think they know the best way to bring Detroit back to her former glory. And it's your way or the highway.

BACKGROUND

"The charred faces, the eyes
boarded up, the rubble of innards, the cry
of wet smoke hanging in your throat,
the twisted river stopped at the color of iron.
We burn this city every day."
-Coming Home, Detroit, 1968 by Philip Levine

There's three kinds of people who live in Detroit: those who love it; those who leave it; and those who eat it. Those who leave run to the suburbs the first chance they get, eager to show the world they "made it" with a picket fence and a respectable zip code. Those who eat it cannibalize it like a scrapyard, grabbing up plots of bankrupt real estate to invest in and leaving them out to rust and rot until they're worth something to someone again.

But you love it. You love Motown music, underground rap, a city that won't apologize for being black; you love the city that's the backbone of American industry, The Paris of the West, the gilded age streets that held America together, that built her beautiful horseless chariot--only to be abandoned, reflected in the rear-view mirror of the cars she built as they drove away from their birth-streets and toward the sundown suburbs.

They abandoned Detroit, but you never will. You want Detroit to rise again, like a phoenix, the center of a new Motor City built by, run by, and providing for native Detroiters.

Motown Showdown casts the players as cabalmates with inclusive but competing visions of Detroit.

- The Motown Breakers are an all-adept cabal of car wizards who believe the future of Motor City is a revived auto industry run by Detroiters.
- The Block Busters are an all-adept cabal of city wizards who believe that Detroit's Michigan Central Station should be the center of an urban train renaissance--a rebuilt Paris of the West run by Detroiters.

As adepts, you're completely consumed by your obsession with your magick. And you've blurred the line between your adept magick and your vision of Detroit's future to the point where you aren't even sure where one ends and the other begins.

Luckily, the two dovetail quite nicely, and your cabal knows a rumor that might give you a shortcut to your goals. The Detroit Occult Underground has long circulated a story that a cabal fighting for the future of Detroit can have the blessing of the city itself--if they pour a significant charge into three separate sites sacred to the spirit of the city and their obsession. The last site must be the intersection of the 375 and the 75: the site of the demolished neighborhood of Black Bottom, which was once the center of black culture in Detroit.

Once the final charge has been offered to the city, a strange otherspace known as the Streets of Motown will open and take on a scion urbanomancer or viaturge. Most adepts who enter the Streets never return--and those who do act completely alien to their former selves, their magick forever changed.

1: BREAKERS: HOME SWEET HOME TURF

The Motown Breakers are enjoying a fairly typical Friday night--street racers from across the Detroit metro are gathered near Woodward avenue in front of the Fortress Burger, a fast-food chain and tuner institution for over 30 years. Your cabal has been discussing potential locations to use in the ritual to summon The Streets of Motown, brainstorming how best to make your dreams of Detroit's

great achievement behind the blue door--but also a threat. This door will extract from the PC a heavy toll indeed, and once they enter, they cannot leave until that toll is paid.

GETTING AGGRO OR GETTING OUT

When the players first appear, how aggressive should their rival cabalmates be? Well, they're metaphorical shadow selves of each other, so I usually have them respond with a similar level of aggression that the PC brings to the table. Does the PC want to talk it out? Feel free to have the GMC rival talk it out. Do they huck that grenade? They're getting one right back.

Either way, though, if they want to get out of the room without killing each other and taking the renunciation, they'll need to brainstorm ways to do so. Make the PC take the lead in figuring that out. You can have the GMC characters passively help them or respond to their ideas, but you shouldn't have the GMC just hand out a solution for how to get out of the Streets.

Also, if the GMCs have been antagonized by the players earlier in the session, they are probably not going to be very helpful. And if the players took the deal, that means one of the rival cabal members has been chosen as *scion*, which means they'll be motivated to huck the grenade.

FREE FOR NOW

If the players escape the Room without using the door, they appear in Lafayette Park, however much the worse for wear. Note that if the players have been drained of their charges by the grenade, they *can* take the time and energy to gain new charges per their adept school's normal charging structure. Sending more than an hour in the eerily vacant fake-streetscape of Detroit is an *Isolation 6 check*, but once they've passed or played out their stress check, they can earn their charges, spend the charges and go. The Streets of Motown counts as Detroit for the urbanomancer's purposes.

KENYA & LATISHA

Kenya and Latisha appear in Island View, a neighborhood in Western Detroit. The beauty of Belle Isle park is visible in the river to the south, but the streetscape is unfamiliar--one side of the street is bounded by beautiful townhouses with single car garages and the other side is an expansive farm dotted with greenhouses and spotted with apartment tower blocks that reach into the sky, their balconies overflowing with greenery.

If Latisha hits Kenya with one of the grenades, the scenery rotates and she appears in a cul-de-sac with young street-racers in electric cars humming full speed at her and Dave, sending several muscle cars slamming into them simultaneously. If Kenya hits Latisha, the tower block rotates ninety degrees full force on top of her, crushing her while Kenya safely rotates in the streetscape alongside the tower.

THEY TOOK THE DEAL: WHAT ABOUT THE SCION?

If the cabal decided to take Thomas Campbell's deal and use Tracy or Lydia in place of one of their own cabalmates, they don't see a battle between Thomas' selection and the rival cabal's scion "onscreen." Although theoretically the room could match up a random member of the rival cabal up with the scion instead of one of your players, leaving a cabalmate without a fight partner is not very interesting from the player perspective. If the players all escape the otherspace ASAP because they're giving up Tracy or Lydia as scion, there's no cost to them, besides the ones they've already paid.

TICKET TO HITSVILLE

If a cabalmate throws a bomb and successfully kills their rival, they get a shortcut to the [Renunciation](#) (pp70). **The room will only accept a scion if they kill their rival and enter the renunciation.** A bright blue door appears in front of them with a bright blue wood awning with arch brackets. There is a small diamond window on the front of the door. The player cannot make out what is inside--only darkness.

The player may make a knowledge roll to recognize the door, which resembles a very famous Motown music studio. Either way, they can sense there is a promise of

automobile renaissance real. Although you've already decided to use Fortress Burger as the site of the first charge drop, there's been a lot of back-and-forth about the second. The cabal has floated Cobo Hall--site of the world-famous international auto show, which is running right now--and Michigan Central Station, a glamorous, decaying beaux-arts train station that various car companies have considered using as a central office for the last ten years. As you compliment each other's cars and sip cheap coffee in the frigid winter air, in your hearts you know you've fallen into a pattern of talking about the potential of the Streets but never really gunning for its prize--a chance to change the future of Detroit. You know one of the cabal would have to be given up as sacrifice. No one has stepped forward. Everyone is afraid to lose themselves or their magick to the Streets. And so you've put off dropping that first charge at Fortress Burger. And what's the hurry? Things are already so bad here in Motor City. How much worse could they get?

Allow the players to mull over the possibility of the ritual for awhile and chat a bit to get into character. Although the game assumes they will use one of the two supplied locations in addition to Black Bottom--Cobo Hall or Michigan Central Station--you should be able to port the action to other similar locations if desired. It is important to note that they will encounter the Urbanomancers twice if they use Michigan Central Station.

If the players dither around too long and put off making any decisions, once everyone has a chance to inhabit the scenery a little, a red Morita tuner with a vinyl decal from the anime *Boku no Super School* decals rolls up, bass thumping. It's owner walks up to the cabal (without turning off the bass) and introduces himself as Leon. With a successful relationship: *Detroit Rap Underground* roll, Nadia Moore recognizes him as a frequenter of Detroit's rap scene (just a fan, not a performer) and a sometime dabbler in the occult.

"You guys better move. Word on the streets is that the *Block Busters* are going to get the blessing of Motown by Sunday night. If you're serious about summoning *The Streets*, you better hustle."

Here are some questions the players may ask, and how Leon might answer them.

- **Who are the Block Busters?** The Block Busters are an all-Urbanomancer cabal--city wizards--obsessed with transit infrastructure and the preservation of the Detroit streetscape. They are not generally big fans of cars; to the extent that they are, they would like cars to be like horses, with their role confined to novelty items for rich aficionados rather than an integral part of the American landscape.
- **How do you know this?** Leon responds that he overheard a Block Buster talking about their plans with a cabal mate at *Mike's Old School Kicks*. With a successful *Connect* roll or relevant relationship, Leon can be pressed for a name: Darius Anderson. *He does not know the names of any of the other Block Busters.*
- **What are the Block Busters going to do?** Leon will ask the cabal if he can join the Motown Breakers and learn viaturgy once they lose their member to the *Streets* in exchange for this information. Doing this may prematurely trigger the cabal's need to decide who will sacrifice themselves; see SOMETHING TO LOSE (pp19) for more details. Leon explains that the Block Busters plan to dump charges into three locations; The first location is the Michigan Building (pp31), the second is MICHIGAN CENTRAL STATION (pp42) and the third is the former site of Black Bottom, where the 375 meets the 75.
- **Will you be the Scion?** Leon can't be the Scion, because he is not a viaturge. However, he will mention that Thomas Campbell (pp26) of UMC is willing to offer a scion to a cabal interested in performing the ritual, and that he is looking for an interested cabal at Cobo Hall (pp24).

Once the players are done grilling Leon, he asks them which one of them is going to become the Scion of the Streets. (Or, if he asked to take the place of a cabal mate, he asks, "which one of you am I replacing?")

Darius, crushing him beneath the buildings of the city. Nadia rotates alongside the new gravitational orientation of the city, casually driving along the streets perpendicular to Darius. If Darius dodges Nadia's hit, gravity reorients for him as well, but only after the city lashes out at him.

LATOYA & RACHEL

Latoya and Rachel materialize in the liminal space between Detroit and Hamtramck, near the auto assembly plant. The auto assembly plant appears not as it does today, however, but instead as the Draft Main plant of the 1970s, a series of boxy buildings one behind the other. In front of Latoya's truck is a covered pedestrian bridge with a huge neon sign that says CARS - **DRAFT** - TRUCKS. On one side of the pedestrian bridge is bustling Hamtramck cityscape, now all demolished in real-life Detroit for the modern Universal Motors Assembly line. On the other side, the Hamtramck streetscape continues along Joseph Campau DR, with a Synagogue flanked by a cemetery with a neat metal sign emblazoned with the letters BETH OLEM CEMETERY.

If Rachel throws a grenade and it hits Latoya, a 1970s era Draft Freight Truck will pummel through the wall of the Assembly factory and down a spontaneously generated interstate ramp at top speed straight into Latoya and her Yosemite Truck, crushing it like a tin can. If Latoya throws a grenade at Rachel, the Pedestrian bridge or nearby cityscape will collapse onto Rachel, crushing her as it lies there like a wounded animal.

JAHID & LEE

Jahid and Lee appear in Brightmoor at dusk, regardless of the time of day the players arrive at the 375. It's alive and vibrant in the twilight of its heyday in the 1970s, the suburban lots fronted by children playing and cars driving up and down the streets.

If Jahid hits Lee with one of the grenades, Lee wakes up inside one of the suburban houses. The wallpaper around him begins to peel and the house, and he, are quickly engulfed in flames. If Lee throws a grenade, a mac truck unexpectedly whips around a suburban corner, slams into Jahid, and explodes.

- If the cabal-member uses *their own* significant blast, instead of the grenade, it fires off *instantly* instead of the normal curse effect caused by the formula. This only works while the cabal-member is being tested by Streets.

Killing another adept in this way is a *Violence 4 check*. You're killing another human being and you know that's what you're doing. It goes without saying these bombs are extremely terrifying and can result in a player's instant death. If the players seem unclear on this, suggest that these are probably shaped like grenades for a reason.

GHOST ROAD ON GHOST ROAD ACTION

What happens when you cast *Ghost Roads* or *Streetwise* in a Room of Renunciation? The Room is, itself, a ghost of Detroit: Casting *Ghost Road* or *Streetwise* in The Streets of Motown casts off the illusion of tiled streets temporarily and shows, simply, what lies underneath the otherspace; a circa 1954 life-sized map of Detroit layered on top of the ground, a "platonic ideal" of Detroit's Motown Spirit, not yet cannibalized by the Big Three, Motown music pumping over the speakers, the prosperity of the auto industry and the American welfare state still casting a golden nostalgic glow over the criss-cross of roads and street names. Also, casting either of these formulas always allows an adept to see the exit to the otherspace back to the 375. Some adept players have also persuasively used other formulas to escape the room, but once they go through the door and the Room has claimed them, only the renunciation will work to escape. Exiting the streets always takes a turn, which means giving their rival the opportunity to strike.

NADIA & DARIUS

Nadia and Darius are hurtled into not a Detroit-that-is but a Detroit-that-never-was -- a thriving, working-class 1990s era Black Bottom Detroit teeming with hip-hop, Detroit techno and street culture. It's cluttered with local thrift and apparel stores, record & CD shops, and bodegas. Nadia's lap is full of the grenades if they are in their car, and Darius holds them in a bright neon backpack and immediately intuits their presence.

Throwing the grenades will cause the city to lash out at the target. For Darius, a Bryant 1990s era *Appaloosa* with bright red flames on the side will spontaneously generate a road that pummels directly toward Nadia at racing speed, T-boning their *itasha*. For Nadia, the 1990s faux-Detroit will rotate 90 degrees straight on top of

LEON

Leon is a character essentially solely intended to drive the plot forward. But sometimes players latch onto him, because he's the first named character the *Viaturses* see. You can find his stats on [PAGE XX.] Leon can't become the scion, no matter how much the players want him to or how convenient he is, because he is *not* a *viaturse*. He's just a pony with an occult chip on his shoulder. He has heard rumors that UMC is willing to offer up a scion, though, and can mention them to the players.

If you're playing with veteran UA players and they know about *proxies*, they can make him a *real viaturse's proxy* and trick the room into believing that he's a member of the Breakers. This is a pretty awful thing to do, and also, you have to get Leon to the actual Streets of Motown, you can't just put it on him covertly and walk away--he has to join your cabal, and both the PC and the proxy have to show up to the Streets, preferably looking as similar as possible.

SOMETHING TO LOSE

It's possible your players will immediately decide who should become the scion; either because someone is willing to step forward, a player legitimately *wants* to become the scion (you'd be surprised), or they feel there's an obvious choice. Since the players are all *viaturses*, there is an obvious choice to decide, however, and Leon will suggest it if no one does:

They can have a race. Last place (or first place, if, uh... more than one person wants to be the scion?) is it.

Note that it's possible that the players will decide to drop the charge *first* and leave the race, or the scion selection, for later. If that happens, see [THE CHARGE DROP](#) (pp22).

THE RACETRACK

Fortress Burger is a small, bright white one-story fast food joint that stands adjacent to Woodward Ave, the main artery of Detroit. Woodward was once a four lane street but is now down to three in the city proper. The "lost lane" is occupied by the tracks for the *Detroit City Mover* streetcar and marked with diagonal yellow

lines. It is widely loathed by Detroiters as a rich investor vanity project made for tourists and transplants. The Train's maintenance facility, The Tech Center, makes a perfect northbound end-point for a drag race; it's a large brick and glass building with a concrete median that ends abruptly at the foot of the building, making a clear and obvious stop point. There is no terminal station here, which shouldn't matter unless the *Breakers* bring this station up to the *Block Busters*.

The *City Mover's* tracks are not bounded by bars or concrete except at its stops, which means cars can easily criss-cross over the tracks where there is no station. The tracks divide the two directions of traffic, though--so doing so is not necessarily a *good idea*.

even more inconvenient location, such as Downtown Detroit or the wealthy, white, mansion-filled section of Detroit known as Grosse Point.

- If the players are just kind of sitting around and watching at a remove, the cops could investigate the portal where the players entered the Room, or try to follow them in after they realize that the players may be antagonizing the rival faction inside. Typically the cops cannot get inside the *Streets of Motown*--they aren't viaturses or urbanomancers--but your players don't know that!

DROP THE BOMB

Once they take another step or continue to drive forward, the PCs are suddenly separated into their own 1950s-era Black bottom Detroit streetscape alongside their shadow self from the rival cabal. Each cabal mate gets three grenade-shaped glass bottles filled with a murky liquid that smells of charcoal and petrol. If they stare at the glass for more than a second, they can see a churning cityscape that rotates in the liquid like a kaleidoscope.

Throwing these bombs:

- Automatically fires off the major blast *Traffic Accident* (Viaturgy) or *Crosstown Traffic* (Urbanomancy), causing 1d100 damage. Yes--**The bomb fires off the significant blast of the opposing school**.
- The GM should offer each player the choice of using their Adept school skill or "Struggle." **If the player chooses their Adept school, they break taboo and are drained of all charges**. They can, however, continue using their adept school to throw future bombs!
- The charge fires *immediately*, instead of the normal curse-effect that these significant formulas cause.
- **However**, The cabal members **can dodge** the charges using any adept formula they can make a reasonable argument for using--this should function exactly the same as *Dodging* on pp62 of *Book 1: Play*, with the attacker taking a -20% shift to their grenade swing. *Face in the Crowd* or *Ghost Roads* are both prime formulas.

KEEP IT MOVING

During this scene, there's a lot of split action between PCs. To keep it moving:

1. Ask the PC what they do, and allow them to take *one action*.
2. Have the GMC respond to that action.
3. Switch to another player.

Doing this allows the players to act independently of each other without spending too much time away from any given PC.

STAYING OUTSIDE: KETTLE THE KETTLERS

What if some players stay behind and decide not to go to the 375? Well, you could just make the Room suck them in anyway (Rooms of Renunciation are not known for being fair and playing by the rules) but unless you're short on time, this feels like punishing players for doing something that is objectively the smartest move, which is avoiding anyone unnecessarily entering the Room and sucking additional scions into the Renunciation.

If the other players are outside, it's worth mentioning that there are cops running around the 375, trying to help the other cabal and keep traffic blockaded. Interfering with the cops to distract them is a good way to keep the other PCs busy. Here are some possibilities:

- If the players have stopped traffic with an event such as a protest or a party, the cops will probably try advancing on the protest. This is significantly less dangerous for the PCs than going toe to toe with cops alone, since they are less likely to murder the PCs, but it's still going to cause injuries as police throw tear gas, kettle GMCs and PCs off the interstate, hit them with beanbags and pepper spray them. Have the PCs help bystanders or try to draw the cops off the interstate by kettling the kettlers.
- The Players could craft a distraction more worthy of police attention than a shut down interstate, like staging a crime elsewhere, causing a major traffic accident, or persuading their relationships to have a protest/block party in an

RUNNING THE RACE

The race is run as a *Grid Iron* (see page 69; page 70, *Chase Scene*, also has helpful rules and ideas.)

1. Take four tokens, one for each player--dice work fine, or you can use minis.
2. Start the players in the middle. This is the "starting line."
3. Have the players roll *pursuit*.
 - a. Each success moves them forward. A *critical* moves them forward two spaces.
 - b. Each failure moves them backward on the grid. A *fumble* moves them backward two steps. They *don't* move backward in the fiction--it just means they aren't keeping up or are lagging behind.
4. Various forms of trickery or cleverness may also provide the PCs shifts on their *pursuit* rolls for better or worse. see *Chase* rules on page 70 and *Viaturgy* rules on page 167 for how specific actions interact on the gridiron during a car chase and/or use your judgement. You got this.
5. If someone reaches the top of the gridiron, the race is over and they are the winner. Whoever is in last place becomes the scion-apparent.
6. Declare the race over after four rounds even if no one reaches the top of the gridiron. Whoever is first wins and last is the scion-apparent. This is to keep the scene from dragging.
7. If last place is a tie, have them roll *pursuit* one last time. Worst roll is Scion.

A RACE TO TAKE YOUR TIME

It's tempting to rush through a gridiron. You need to pull out your paper, gather your tokens, trudge through any rules that affect car chases. **Resist the temptation.** After each player makes their roll, take the time to ask them what they're doing. Describe the feel of their car and their hands on the wheel. If they're using their viaturge powers, take the moment to really capture the atmosphere and strangeness of this supernatural race. If they succeed or fail, moving forward or backward on the "track", describe *why*. Failures or successes may happen for mundane reasons, like passing a car just right or failing to drift, but the reasons

should be described, preferably by the players themselves. Just rolling four dice rolls in a row is *boring*. **If you feel really uncomfortable having a long, drawn out race, or your players are already putzing around in the first scene of the game and you feel pressed for time, it's better just to skip the gridiron entirely and run the race as a normal roll with the best roll winning and the worst as the scion-apparent.** I'm giving you permission to do that, so just do that if you need to!

It's also worth paying attention to if the players use their *Viaturgy* formulas during the race. Did they make a gentleman's agreement not to? If so, that's a nice bit of tension if someone wins after using *I Am the Highway*. (Maybe that means they're the scion now.) If everyone uses *I Am the Highway*, they're just going to force themselves to do the race all over again, because the winner will be impossible to determine. (Well... unless someone fails the roll.)

After the race, have the players reconvene at *Fortress Burger* and definitively choose who will be the scion. If the *Breakers* pursue their intention to evoke the streets at Black Bottom, that player character's life is forfeit.

THE CHARGE DROP

Because the players are in a group of trusted peers, and the first charge drop location is a regular haunt, the charge effects are overwhelmingly positive and there aren't any ill effects. In other words; first drop's a gimmie.

As the magical energy pours into the track around *Fortress Burger*, Funk music pours out of speakers in all of the cars. Vintage autos appear in the parking lots nearby out of nowhere, and the hip-hop begins to morph into classic Detroit techno as souped up cars zoom by. No-one is sure where they came from. As the cars race by, the depot station for the Detroit People Mover dissolves, and the bus stop for the North End appears as horns honk and engines rev in the night. The scene around *Fortress Burger* ascends from a casual meet up to a full on party, folks dancing beside their cars in the night.

buys them a little time out of character to decide how to respond to the other Adept.) The room does not have any interest in honoring an agreement to take only a scion, and would like to take as many worthy people as possible. The players ultimate goal, whether or not they realize it, is:

- Win against or escape from their rival chosen by the room
 - and get out of the Streets of Motown
 - except for the one person they've selected as the scion. **The room has to take at least one person, or it will not help them with their objective.**
- And the scion *must* kill their rival.

If this sounds difficult to intuit for the players that's because it is, and the players will be lucky if they come out of this with three cabal members.

WHAT THE HELL AM I DOING HERE?

As the GM, you should telegraph any information about the Streets of Motown you think that it's reasonable for the cabal to pick up on. Statements like, "*it almost feels like the Streets want you to fight, perhaps to prove your worth*" are absolutely ok. If players wander around instead of fighting their rival, you should be up front and say, "*You feel like you're wandering aimlessly, going in circles, and there's no obvious exit. You think you're either going to have to use those grenades or find your own way out.*" When I run *Motown*, I usually don't incentivize any players that **aren't the scion** to fight, because that's not necessarily to their benefit this late in the game. Of course, taking out some rival Adepts would put them closer to their objective...

The charge location is in the middle of an interstate and dropping a charge in such a location is inherently dangerous. You should ask the players what they plan to do to mitigate the danger. Some possibilities include:

- Going to the location of the charge in the middle of the night (remember, if it's dark out the PCs are harder to see for oncoming cars)
- Blockading traffic somehow. Getting a crowd of sufficient size is possible for this, especially for the viaturges--Detroit street racers have been known to blockade interstates to do tricks or races, though this is obviously not done without consequence. Remember that blockading the street in this fashion is likely to cause a *riot* if they have gathered a sufficiently large crowd due to the unnatural phenomena.
- Both schools can create an impromptu magical effect to change street traffic based on their magick domain by dropping an additional 2-3 significant charges, depending on how much they're altering the world. This should be clearly relevant to their school and also, interesting and creative. Impromptu magickal domain effects are extremely cool but they should be used with caution or they can be, bluntly, extremely broken.
- If the players accepted Thomas Campbell's deal, the 375 will already be blockaded. The cops will let them pass.

It's January in Detroit and when the players arrive, especially if it's in the middle of the night, it will be brutally cold, the wind off the water whipping against their faces and weak, icy snowflakes battering their eyelashes.

As the significant charge is dropped the streets rise up the demolished buildings of Black Bottom, and it appears in all of it's 1949 glory, a vibrant working-class black neighborhood of shops and streets.

From that moment the players aren't in Detroit anymore. They are in the Room's territory.

The room instantly splits the PC cabal apart and isolates them with a member of a rival cabal. The Room is trying to decide which to take--the urbanomancer or the viaturge. Being teleported in this way is an *unnatural 4 check* for the cabal. (It also

The moment after this first charge is dropped feels jubilant and safe, a promise of a better world. Fade to black, and ask the PCs where they will drop their second charge: Cobo Hall or Michigan Central Station. If you wish, the players can also explore OTHER POSSIBILITIES FOR THE MOTOWN BREAKERS (pp23).

OTHER POSSIBILITIES FOR THE MOTOWN BREAKERS

It's possible the players will ignore the convenient plot coupon you've given them and get their own ideas about where they dump the charge. If you feel comfortable improvising, feel free to make use of the below alternatives:

- **AN AUTO PLANT** - There is still one large auto assembly plant in Detroit, on the border of Hamtramck, currently owned by UMC. It was formerly the site of a Draft plant, which was bought by UMC, razed to the ground, and rebuilt. It's also the site of intense, historic labor struggle, and a shocking number of deaths during the 1960s and 70s when production efficiency was pushed to unsafe extremes, mostly on the backs of Blacks and to a lesser extent Appalachian and Arab workers. Feel free to export the picket line (pp25) and DEAL FACE TURN (pp26) into the Auto Plant if desired.
- **A MECHANIC SHOP** - Unless the players can make a compelling case for why it's important to the auto history or symbolism of Detroit, this is pretty weak tea. The PCs would probably know this is risky and you should tell them so. If they do choose to dump a charge here, the Phenomena should be less significant, especially as it's of less interest to The Streets (pp57).
- **THE HISTORIC WORKSHOP OF DRAFT OR BRYANT** - Bryant's workshop is famously on the site of the Michigan Building, and *inside* the Michigan Building is the remains of the Michigan Theater crumbling above the parking garage. This is also the haunt of the Block Busters, the rival cabal. You can find out more about this location under BUSTERS: THE PARIS OF THE WEST (pp31). Draft Motors was founded in the Boydell Building near Greektown in downtown Detroit. It's currently an apartment building with a Greek restaurant on the ground floor. Both are excellent locations to dump a charge, though the Michigan Building--as a car workshop turned theater turned parking garage--is the more potent of the two.

2: BREAKERS: COBO HALL

The auto show Leon is referring to is the American International Auto Show, which takes place every year at Cobo Hall in January. It is a major world event for automotive product unveilings. The keystone event is the Charity Gala; it is taking place tonight (Friday), and is starting just as the players are wrapping up their charge drop at Fortress Burger. The players do not need to go at the same time as the charity gala for their charge dump to work.

The auto show takes place across four convention halls, comprising the entire first floor of the Hall. In addition to a presence by all the major carmakers, there are vendors throughout. The Charity Gala is beneath it on the ground floor, near the riverwalk, in a convention hall of its own. The creme de la creme of auto executives and designers attend. Outside, there is a huge parking garage the players may make use of to park their vehicles for a modest fee. You must enter the auto show from the outside; there is no entrance directly through the parking garage, so the players must go through the front door unless they use one of the service entrances behind the back. There are four of these, including one central, giant garage-door gate through which the display cars on the event hall floor are driven.

Outside of Cobo Hall is a contingent of Union Workers protesting the closure of a Detroit auto plant Universal Motors is threatening to shut down. If the Breakers go to Cobo Hall at night, there is a nighttime vigil of autoworkers against the plant's shutdown, rather than a rally.

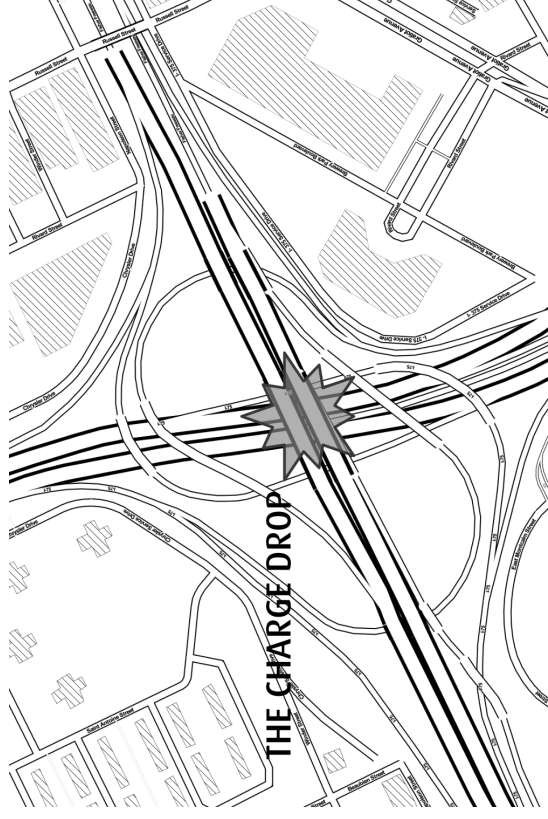
SOME IMPORTANT DETAILS

- The main event hall is *studded with premium luxury cars*.
- The cabal may wish to use the channel *I Am the Highway* to skip the annoyance of entering the convention and just... rubber-band straight onto the floor in their vehicles. In order to do this, however, they need an unobstructed route. Cars absolutely can make it to the convention floor, but the players will need to get the gate open *first*. Also, once they're *on* the

-10% and increase all stress checks by 1 notch, or stronger stimulants, which will eliminate the shift and increase all stress checks by 2 notches.

If time is running shorter and the players are ahead of the rival cabal because they've already beaten them back so much that it only makes sense for their rivals to lick their wounds or recuperate, then you can have the players skip the fight entirely and just get the door straightaway. They've already proven themselves willing to do what it takes to accomplish their goals, for better or worse.

The deal proffered by the Streets is basically honest; if the Streets get their scion and their three charges, the Streets of Motown will use its agents and power over Detroit to bend the power of the city to the cabal objective as much as possible. The streets aren't God, though, and Detroit's history as the center of gravity for urban redevelopment experiments ensures that the path to the players' objectives will be far from easy, even with the Room's assistance.



KEEP IT TOGETHER

A lot can happen in this scene. Although I've given you a lot of ingredients for chaos in Michigan Central Station, you should take it slow and let yourself consider how each of the actors in the scene--The Motown Breakers, the Block Busters, and the cops--react to each other and in what order. Don't feel like you have to hew too closely to the elements of chaos I've listed, either--feel free to mix things up to feel thematically appropriate. It's a better use of your time to familiarize yourself with the rival cabal and decide on their MO than it is to remember every possible thing that can happen in Michigan Central Station.

4. MOTOWN SHOWDOWN: THE FATE OF MOTOR CITY

Regardless of where the players have been dropping their charges up until now, the final charge must, to make the deal with the Streets of Motown successful, be dropped at the intersection of the 75 and the 375--the former site of Black Bottom, a vibrant black neighborhood and center of working-class Detroit that was demolished in 1956. If the players accept Thomas Campbell's deal he will call or text Kenya or Darius and let them know Lydia or Tracy will be waiting for them there, along with a blockade of the 375 which they will be let through.

AHEAD OF THE GAME

Many players pursue their own objective as quickly as possible, often deliberately avoiding the other cabal. Others do the opposite--deliberately swiping or provoking the other cabal to try and get the edge on them.

What if the players do so well against their rivals--dropping all 3 charges during Friday night, or pulling a major defeat against the rival cabal--that the rival cabal simply never arrives in Black Bottom? That it doesn't make sense for them to "face off" against their rivals in the Streets of Motown?

You have two options. If the players are in Black Bottom early because they just pushed themselves really hard, trying to get all the charges in one night, for example, you should create doppelganger versions of themselves in the Room, using exactly the same stats as the player characters. Killing themselves in this way won't hurt the player characters, they're just constructions for the room to test the PCs. But you should instead have them take an *unnatural rank 6* check when/if they kill themselves. Also: if your players dropped all 3 charges in one night, you should give them a -20% penalty in the final scene from sleep deprivation. The effects can be mitigated with coffee, which will lower the shift to

convention floor, they will need to put their cars... somewhere... that won't result in them being booted or worse.

- Kenya knows some of the vendors outside the event space in the hallway, who are likely to be, at least in part, Detroit Mechanics and professional tuners.
- Latoya knows some of the picketers outside the hall, both from *Black Detroit Matters* and from her father's time working at the auto plant.

OUTSIDE COBO HALL: THE SOUL OF DETROIT

If the players decide to approach the front entrance of the hall, Latoya Murphy immediately recognizes many of the picketers in the crowd from her relationship with *Black Detroit Matters*. The crowd is a diverse crew--though decidedly whiter than Detroit proper--holding signs with slogans like "STOP OUTSOURCING DETROIT JOBS" and "WORKERS ARE NOT DISPOSABLE." They're more auto-workers than activists, but there's overlap.

The picket line is led by a heavy-set white man with a bushy brown beard, Tim Bicknell, and an elderly organizer and Shop Steward with a salt-and-pepper afro, Fred North. Latoya immediately recognizes Fred and may find Tim vaguely familiar as an auto-plant worker.

Fred approaches Latoya to have a potentially awkward conversation if he sees her:

- He will ask her if she is planning on joining the picket line and/or vigil.
- If she is going into the Hall to the auto show, he will ask her why she's supporting the greedy execs taking away good American jobs.
- What if Latoya tells him the truth, or some variant of the truth with the supernatural bits censored out?
 - If she just straight up tells him about the automotive ritual, he tries to convince her she's going down a dark path and saving the auto workers isn't worth becoming a sinner. (While Fred is a religious man,

he's not superstitious enough that he actually believes this will work or risk her soul. But he believes she believes.)

- If she doesn't tell him the truth but tells him something vaguely evocative of what they're planning, like that they have a "surprise" or they're going to "fix everything", he warns her about how this kind of radicalism doesn't usually end well for folks like us and begs her to reconsider.
- Unless Latoya says something that Fred thinks will actually put the picket line at risk, he will not narc on her. **Tim, however, will call the cops if he thinks Latoya is going to do something dangerous or illegal.** A successful *Black Detroit Matters* or *Connect* roll should give Latoya the sense that Tim is not as trustworthy as Fred. Calling the cops is really, really bad for the cabal and you should make it very clear to them that they do not want this to happen. See **THE POLICE** for more details.

INSIDE THE HALL: FACE DEAL TURN

If the players openly enter the convention hall floor, there are throngs of people congregating around various American luxury cars, SUVs, trucks, and the occasional electric car. If they enter any public space without obscuring their presence--be it the convention floor or the gala itself--A tall white man in a blue suit will eventually approach them. This is Thomas Campbell (pp64), the avatar of the Salesman for UMC. (See the Appendix for details.) He looks aggressively bland, with a crew cut and the air of someone who is entirely unflappable.

Thomas Campbell tells the cabal he has heard about their exciting vision of Detroit and wants to help make it happen. He says that he has a deal for them: he will provide an alternate scion for the Streets of Motown so that they do not have to sacrifice a member of their cabal to the Streets. In exchange, UMC must be allowed to pick the scion.

well-to-do ghostly passengers will begin involving transit police. The violence doesn't involve the players... as long as they stay out of the eye of the charge drop, where the ghostly figures become real and the riot causes the effects detailed on pp94 of *Book 2* or the section on Cobo Hall entitled ...AND WHAT HAPPENS WHEN YOU DO (pp29). Note that since most players will drop the charge either on the truck or the train, it's very likely that the eye of the charge drop and the bullet trains are in the exact same location.

- When the auto factory appears on the station floor, it may crush or injure the ghostly figures who were moving through the station.
- Union workers wearing hi-vis vests from the train station may begin dismantling the auto-factory equipment, especially if it's in the way of the passenger's egress. This will also prompt a *riot roll* if one has not already been prompted, this one led initially by factory foremen.

Remember that having both of these charges pumping magick through Central Station at the same time is asking two ideas of Detroit, deeply in tension, to exist together. The car can't be King of Detroit if we live in a post-auto age. The spirits of these two visions are inherently antagonistic as spirits animated by the rival cabal's concerns--even if real humans that existed in this world would be considerably more self-interested and rational.

THEY TOOK THE DEAL

If the players took Thomas Campbell's (pp64) deal in DEAL FACE TURN, The cops freely give way for the players to enter Michigan Central station. If the players took the deal, **they will always arrive at Central Station first.** The players can then dump their charge mostly consequence free, which causes the effects listed in THE CHARGE DROPS (pp44). (Remember: don't include any of the rival cabal's effects.) After the players have dropped their charge, run the section GETTING THE DROP ON 'EM: BEFORE 10AM (pp46).

stern faces of the black activists on the wall warp and blend into conductors, passengers, and floor staff, the hazy, ambiguous logo of a union--does it say carmen's? Train-workers? Engineers?--emblazoned on the backs of their hi-vis vests.

- In the eye of the charge drop, the ghostly figures become real.
- The Amtrak train fires to life and a mostly-black crowd files into an immaculately clean and perfectly maintained bullet train.
- Outside of Michigan Central, the tetrís, maze-like streets of the Streets of Motown (pp69) appear as a faint ghostly overlay over the parking lots and front field of Michigan Central. If they go through the front entrance, everyone should make an *unnatural* 6 check, including the cops if they are still there. Any cops that pass this check should roll to shoot one of the PCs. You can find more info on combat on pp64 of *Book One: Play*.

TOGETHER

If the two charges combine, the effects combine into a horrifying mishmash of competing priorities. Whichever cabal got the drop on the other should have the more prominent/powerful effects. Feel free to riff on players ideas or read the room--these are ideas to heighten the feeling of insanity and danger.

- If the Block Busters drop the first charge, and any of the viaturge's cars are inside the station, they become 1d5 levels more damaged than they are now:

1	Fumble only. Won't start. Car is totally rusted and totaled.
2	Rusty. Wheels warped.
3	Windows smashed; tires flattened
4	Paint chipped; worn
5	The cars change color but are otherwise unaffected.

- The ghostly figures of autoworkers will act on the bullet trains as if they have failed a *riot roll* and begin vandalizing them. Hi-vis vest wearers at the train station begin trying to pull them off the train, escalating the violence;

If players ask the identity of the Scion, his name is Tracy Gates (pp66). He is the owner of a local Detroit Draft Cars dealership who worked his way into the position as a former certified Draft Mechanic. Tracy is a Viaturge, but what's known as a Lesser Magi; an Adept who has essentially fallen off the wagon and lives a more-or-less normal life while collecting occasional minor viaturgy charges and doing magick for casuals. With a successful *relationship* roll, Kenya would recognize his name as a prominent mechanic-turned-dealership owner. She hasn't heard anything *bad* about Tracy--he's lived in Detroit his whole life and used to be a regular in the tuner scene--but any mechanic that works for a dealership is seen as a little suspect and potentially a sell-out to an independent mechanic. That said... she doesn't know anything *darnning* about him either.

If the Breakers want to meet Tracy, they're free to do so. He has a vendor booth set up in the main hall for his dealership, Gates Draft Dealership.

If the cabal accepts his deal, The Salesman will use his second channel to make the deal. There are no catches or hidden clauses in this deal--having a man on the inside of the Streets of Motown is basically its own reward for the Big Three. Their goal is to try and warp the streets in their own image using whichever of the two cabals is successful, though of course, the Room (pp67) has its own agenda.

NO DEAL

What if the players refuse the deal? Well, for one, whoever is going to be sacrificed as the Scion still has that hanging over their head. It's a good idea to remind the players that refusing this deal means throwing one of their own under the bus to an uncertain future. Of course, if they're enthusiastic to become a servant of the Streets, maybe that's fine by them. Or maybe the alternative of working with UMC is worse. (Which: fair.)

Thomas Campbell is not happy to be refused but he is not what you would call a heavy hitter; he may offer the below enticements to "sweeten the deal." Thomas will give them in this order, because they are increasingly inconvenient to him.

- He will offer jobs to the entire cabal working for Universal Motors. Remind the players that all of them are either unemployed or precariously employed

except for Kenya. Remind the players *how much this sucks for them*. The Salesman cannot coerce them, and refusing this deal does not cause a *unnatural* stress check, but it does cause a boring 'ol mundane *Helplessness* rank 3 stress check for every cabal member but Kenya as the players watch the promise of three square meals a day and a steady roof over their head fly away for a vague, distant promise of a "better Detroit" that may never materialize, and will only do so at the cost of one of their cabalmates' sanity.

- If they agree to this deal, he will tell them the location of the Block Busters home base. It is The Michigan Building, a once-glorious theater that was half-heartedly turned into a parking garage. The cabal will almost certainly meet here before going to Black Bottom and they could use it as an opportunity to trap them and prevent them from dumping charges.

- He will clear the floor of Cobo Hall for 20 minutes while they dump a charge, guaranteeing both a minimum amount of disruption to the surroundings and also guaranteeing their safety from having the cops called.

If the players still refuse, that's fine. Thomas Campbell will walk away and let them go on with their day. He will take the following actions, however:

- He will offer the same deal to the Block Busters. If the Block Busters are NPCs, they automatically accept the deal. (Which I am sure will give your players a lovely post-hoc rationalization for why they are Bad People who deserve to lose.) *This gives the Block Busters basically a free and easy pass to Michigan Central Station*. Which matters because

- The Big Three and UMC in particular will now be watching Michigan Central Station and the section of the 375 once known as Black Bottom like a hawk. Security details and/or cops will be lurking around these areas, which the players will now have to avoid and the Block Busters will not.

What if the players just avoid Thomas Campbell entirely? This is certainly possible, for one, by dumping their charge somewhere else (See: OTHER POSSIBILITIES (pp36) or simply by running Cobo Hall as a heist or a stealth mission. If the players avoid Thomas Campbell, you have two options; you can either just leave him out of the game entirely--it won't "break" anything!--or you can have him pop up

- A giant sign on the wall of the mural emblazoned with the words "United Car Workers" appears; a mural below it evokes Diego Rivera's famous mural of Detroit autoworkers on the assembly line.
- The lines between the mural and reality become blurry as ghostly, maimed autoworkers appear in Michigan Central station and auto assembly machinery spontaneously generates on the floor of Central Station. If there are ghostly Detroiters who came for the train service from the urbanomancer charge, they look on in bewildered confusion.
- In the eye of the charge drop, the ghostly figures become real.
- The abandoned car on the tracks revives to life, and it seems to loom in height and width beyond even the full-sized, rusted out amtrak car. Auto workers jump on the hatchback of the truck holding strike signs that look dated from the 1970s that say "I DON'T MIND WORKING, I DO MIND DYING" and "NO UNION IS ABOUT US WITHOUT US"
- Outside of Michigan Central, the tetrises, maze-like streets of the Streets of Motown (pp69) appear as a faint ghostly overlay on top of the parking lots and front field of Michigan Central. Everyone should make an *unnatural* 6 check, and don't forget to include THE COPS (pp43) and their reactions if they are there.

The effect dissipates after 1 hour.

BUSTERS

The Busters charge causes the below effects:

- Michigan Central temporarily appears restored to its former glory, but all of the most artistic and elaborate graffiti remains layered on top of its Beaux Arts decoration.
- Trains appear to pull in and out of the station, and there are ghostly Detroiters filtering in and out.
- Spanning across the wall of the concourse, Eda Wade and Bill Walker's *Wall of Dignity* mural lives again, the wall of the train station alive with vibrant mural images of black history, activists, and organizers in Detroit. The fierce,

the effects of this formula can be avoided if the PC uses magical means to navigate somewhere, which a viatarge absolutely can.)

- The Motown Breakers have dropped the formula **Lifetime Piling Up**, causing a *rank 4 helplessness check* to all of the Block Busters. The Viatarges are arrayed around the building in their cars beside the track viaduct, facing the Breakers. While another Breaker drops the charge, Nadia Moore puts on her sunglasses in her *itasha* and tells the Busters that if they don't leave Central Station *immediately*, she will doom one of them to be hit by a car the next time they step in the street by using **Crosstown Traffic**.

Both cabals should take the opportunities granted to them by their formulas to tell the other cabal to fuck off or fuck around and find out. If the other cabal succeeds, that means failure for them. Remember, too, that one or both of the cabals can attempt to incite a riot with the figures that appear in the station when they drop a charge. For more info, see THE CHARGE DROP (pp48).

DEPARTURES: THE CHARGE DROP

Each cabal has a set of *charge effects* that manifest when they dump their charge in Michigan Central Station. You should feel free to ad-lib as necessary or desired based on where the players specifically drop their charge in or near the station.

When one cabal arrives after the other, if they choose to add an additional charge into the mix, those effects *layer and interact*. If that happens--things get very strange very fast. For each cabal's charge effects, see below; for ideas on how to make the charges interact, see TOGETHER.

BREAKERS

The Viaturge's charge causes the following effects:

- all of the viatarges cars instantly restore damage per "Jesus Built My Hot Rod" on page 169 of *play*. If the cars are already mint, they are car-smell brand new.

elsewhere. The players are never under any obligation to take his deal, so reinserting him at, say, a dealership or an auto plant isn't going to force their hand, and anywhere the Big Three operates is a perfectly logical location for him to pop up, especially if he's keeping an eye on Detroit occult activity. The whole point of the Salesman's second channel is that his deal has to be freely accepted. Tonally, the point of the Salesman deal is to ask your players if they're willing to sell out their vision of an inclusive Detroit *just a little* to guarantee themselves a life of comparative comfort. That's a position that the marginalized are frequently put in, and frankly, I can't say as I blame them for doing it. Living on the edge *sucks*.

WHERE TO DUMP THE CHARGE

It's good to encourage the players to dump the charge in the most symbolically resonant part of the convention. What that means is sort of up to them; you should accept any answer that they provide a good justification for. But the three obvious locations to drop a charge are:

1. **The Main Floor of the Convention** - this is where all of the cars, booths, and excitement of the convention happen.
2. **The Charity Gala** - taking place on the floor beneath, this area is a fancy soiree filled with top automotive brass. This is only an option if they go Friday night.
3. **The Union Picket Line** - Symbolic because of the presence of disenfranchised automotive workers pushing against the big three. Has the advantage of avoiding the most red tape and security and the disadvantage of being extremely open, as well as exposing workers to the brunt of the unnatural phenomena.

...AND WHAT HAPPENS WHEN YOU DO

Dumping a Significant charge into the ambient environment triggers a Significant Phenomena. For the first few moments after releasing their charge, there is a pleasant ambient buzzing in the atmosphere, like how you feel after drinking a really strong coffee or an energy drink for the first time.

Then things get weird. *Really weird*. All of the cars in the area--including all of the cars on the display floor--start their ignition and begin to rev their engine. (Even if they are electric cars, they make an engine revving sound.) If the picket line is visible to the players, it's padded out with a bunch more people who seem to have come from nowhere, all of them working class Detroiters. Any additional crowd members with the union picketers chant enthusiastically alongside them. If the players are in the gala, all of the alcohol turns into gasoline and oil begins leaking through the walls. The sounds of car traffic and protest chants echo loudly and disconcertingly regardless of where the players find themselves, and drown out any other noise in the convention.

If the players did not bring their cars onto the convention floor, they absolutely can hop into one of the floor models and drive away using their *viaturny* channels (though then they have to worry about getting rid of a stolen vehicle...)

The effect lasts about twenty minutes. Also, all of the additional people protesting have teleported there from various parts of the city, with no memory of how they got there after the twenty minutes is up. The cars all go quiet, the walls look like they never had oil on them, and the alcohol is alcohol again.

Once the significant phenomena has ended, if the players are still there, you should make a riot roll per the rules on pp94 of Book 2, *Run* if the the players are either at the charity gala or the picket line. If they are on the auto show floor during the open hours of the convention, give the roll a +25% shift--there are so many people here that it is absolutely guaranteed there will be chaos.

ROLL	RESULTS
1-25	The crowd is definitely confused and disoriented, looking around and staring dumbstruck at the weirdness around them. But they aren't violent.
26-50	Everyone who isn't already injured to weird supernatural shit runs away. Add the dice rolled together: That's how many people are seriously injured as panicked humans run out of the area from a failed stress check.

At that point, the Urbanomancers and Viaturnes should roll any relevant abilities--struggle, pursuit, fitness--to see if:

- The player cabal are able to effectively chase off, subdue, or otherwise stop the rival cabal before
- The rival cabal successfully drops their own charge
- And the rival cabal drops the formulas:
 - a. **Break your Mother's Back** and/or **Wrong Turn** if they are urbanomancers
 - b. **Lifetime Piling Up** and/or **Crosstown Traffic** (on 1 target) if they are Viaturnes.

Of course, maybe they get in a brawl, in which case, see page 66 of *Book One: Play*. Remember that if the rival cabal does manage to drop their charge there's *already* an ongoing riot at ground zero in Central Station, everyone has to have already made and passed their *unnatural* checks (though if they choose frenzy, that will only make a brawl even more likely) and they may have to avoid or ignore whatever significant phenomena is already going on in the background. None of the characters on either side are particularly good at fighting, either.

GET IN LINE: AFTER 10AM

If the players arrive at Michigan Central Station after 10AM on Saturday, the rival cabal is already there and is moments away from dropping their charge. The cabal is primarily focused on launching their charge and leaving, not having a protracted shake-down, especially since neither cabal is really oriented around combat. However, each cabal is definitely motivated to prevent the other's success, and they should try to entice, threaten, or scare the rival cabal before they drop a second charge if they think that's possible without fucking themselves over in the process. If the rival cabal arrives at central station first:

- The Block Busters have dropped **Break Your Mother's Back**. This fires on any Breaker who does not make a Dodge check, and they take 2d10 damage (or their ride does) and a rank 2 or 3 helplessness check. 1 Viaturne player will be afflicted with the urbanomancy formula **Wrong Turn**. (Remember,

The General Waiting room is a once-grand affair with a couple remaining broken-down plastic benches and chipped wood panels covered in graffiti with elaborate, lavish tags beneath scrollwork windows. One of the graffiti hastily spells out "THIS IS YOUR CITY ON DRUGS", while another one opines "MOTOR CITY: BY THE PEOPLE FOR THE PROFITEERS" in 90s-style neon font with elaborate serifs. Moving to the old track viaduct, there are two wrecked vehicles haphazardly spread over what's left of the track at the bottom of the ramp next to the old baggage claim; a rusted-up 1980s era-amtrak car covered in colorful graffiti, and a beat-up Bryant truck from the same era, itself covered in graffiti and rust.

ARRIVALS

If the cabal arrives before 10AM, there's only one COP (pp35) car outside, which is simply monitoring the property on behalf of UMC. If the players arrive at Michigan Central station **before 10AM** and before talking to Thomas Campbell (see DEAL FACE TURN), the inside of the station is abandoned. The players can dump the charge... well, not consequence free, but... with fewer consequences. For what happens when they do, see THE CHARGE DROP (pp48). (Make sure only the player cabal's effects are in play!) They will probably take the hint and dump their charge into the abandoned Bryant car or the Amtrak car, but anywhere will trigger the effects. At this point, the charge effects will fire off just as the rival cabal arrives. If the PC cabal arrives **after 10AM** on Saturday remember that they will encounter THE COPS. Once they enter the station, they will also encounter the rival cabal, who is already there: see GET IN LINE: AFTER 10AM (pp47).

HORIZONTAL HOSTILITY

GETTING THE DROP ON 'EM: BEFORE 10AM

If the players arrive in the morning, before 10AM on Saturday, first allow them to drop their charge. (See THE CHARGE DROP pp48 for effects.) After the players have dropped their charge, have the PC cabal make a *Notice* roll at a -20% shift. If they do so, they see the other cabal sneaking into Central Station from the track viaduct.

51+	The number rolled is how many people are seriously injured in the riot. If the riot roll is a fumble, ten people are hospitalized in the ICU and one person dies.
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After the events of Cobo Hall, if it's still Friday night, it will be quite late and very dark, and the players should probably go to bed.

Once the second charge has been laid, the players must lay the final charge to open the gateway to the streets and give up the Scion. See 4. MOTOWN SHOWDOWN: THE FATE OF MOTOR CITY (pp52).

1: BUSTERS: THE PARIS OF THE WEST

The Block Busters are assembled in one of their regular haunts on a Friday Night, The Michigan Building parking garage, where they congregate around or inside of Darius' minivan to shoot the shit in the frigid January air. The Michigan Building was once a grand beaux arts theater, one of the gems of the Paris of the West, but now the theater's deteriorating interior arches like a cathedral, faded and half-wrecked, above a parking garage. Your cabal has been discussing potential locations to use in the ritual to summon The Streets of Motown for months, brainstorming how best to make your dreams of Detroit's revival as the center of modern urbanism a reality. Although you've already decided to use Michigan Theater as the site of the first charge drop, there's been a lot of back-and-forth about the second. The cabal has floated Eastern Market--the largest open air market in the United States--and Michigan Central Station, a glamorous, decaying train station that various car companies have considered using as a central office for the last ten years. As you listen to Darius pump Detroit Hip-Hop through his speakers, in your hearts you know you've fallen into a pattern of talking about the potential of the Streets but never really gunning for its prize--a chance to change the future of Detroit. You know one of the cabal would have to be given up as sacrifice. No one has stepped forward. Everyone is afraid to lose themselves, or worse, their magick to the Streets. And so you've put off dropping that first charge here at Michigan Theater.

And what's the hurry? Things are already so bad here in Motor City. How much worse could they get?

Allow the players to mull over the possibility of the ritual for awhile and chat a bit to get into character. Although the game assumes they will use the two supplied locations in addition to Black Bottom--Eastern Market and Michigan Central Station--you should be able to port the action to other similar locations. It is important to note that they will encounter the Viaturges if they use Michigan Central Station.

If the players seem to be struggling with what they're supposed to be doing, feel free to remind them of the suggested charge locations and encourage them to talk over which they prefer. Remind them that someone will need to be chosen as a Scion at the last drop. You can be open about the potential pitfalls and bonuses of different locations, as long as it's something the players would realistically know.

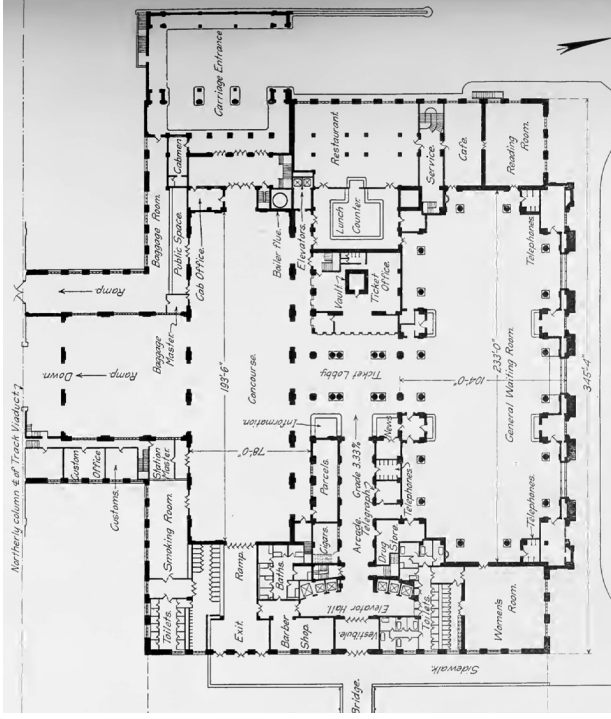
FACE DEAL TURN

Once the Players have gone back and forth about what to do for a few moments, A tall white man in a blue suit will eventually approach Darius' minivan. This is Thomas Campbell (pp64), the Salesman for UMC. He looks aggressively bland, with a crew cut and the air of someone who is entirely unflappable.

Thomas Campbell tells the cabal he has heard about their exciting vision of Detroit and wants to help make it happen, especially as there is a rumor that a rival cabal of car wizards is about to try for the Streets of Motown any day now. He says that he has a deal for them: he will provide an alternate scion for the Streets of Motown so that they do not have to sacrifice a member of their cabal to the Streets. In exchange, UMC must be allowed to pick the scion.

If players ask the identity of the Scion, her name is Lydia Gauthier (pp67), and she works for Bryant Motor Company's transit and engineering division, building trains and buses for American urban centers. She started out as a bus mechanic for The Detroit Transit agency and worked her way into a much better gig. Lydia is an urbanomancer and what's known as a Lesser Magi--an Adept who no longer

This map is from 1914, but the rough floor plan is still more or less the same:



RUIN PORN & THE REAL MICHIGAN CENTRAL STATION

As of this writing (2020), the real-life Michigan Central Station is currently being renovated, and Central Station would probably be teeming with construction workers at any time during working hours.

This game takes place a few years before that, in roughly 2018, when the station is owned by a real-life car company but not yet under construction. Michigan Central Station is one of the most famous sites of "ruin porn", a beautiful beaux arts building allowed to crumble after the age of trains. It's beloved by most Detroiters, but there is an element of voyeurism in the taking photos of its long-standing deterioration--especially because of the tendency for white Americans to fetishize Detroit as "abandoned," despite the fact that the city is still very much occupied by its citizens.

AFTER THE CHARGE DROPS

If when the players leave they go through the front exit after dropping their charge (see THE CHARGE DROP pp48) and the cops are still there, the police should make an *unnatural* 6 check. Any cops that pass this check should roll to shoot one of the PCs. You can find more info on combat on pp64 of *Book One: Play*.

Remember, if the players are running away on foot, there is a chance that a cop may hit them with their car because of the formula **Break Your Mothers Back** or **Crosstown Traffic** (if Nadia made good on their threat), and another player, if they are not using a viaturgy charge to get away, may get lost due to **Wrong Turn**.

INSIDE THE STATION

Inside, the basic floor plan has changed little since its creation, but of course all of the rooms are empty except for their ruined scroll work and wood paneling and tons and tons of graffiti decorating the walls.

seriously practices their magick and has fallen "off the wagon." Darius has probably heard her name as someone who worked on and helped finance the Detroit City Mover, the selfsame public transit project that stabbed working people in the back by cutting off bus access to the poorer parts of the city. Of course, he also worked on that project, and he's cool, so...

If the cabal wants to talk to Lydia, Thomas Campbell directs them inside the building to a American Bistro downstairs to have coffee with her. She is a tall smartly-dressed woman with a narrow frame and short, finger waved hair. Her expertly done makeup makes her age difficult to judge.

If the cabal accepts his deal, The Salesman will use his second channel as a Salesman to make the deal. There are no catches or hidden clauses in this deal--having a man on the inside of the Streets of Motown is basically its own reward for the Big Three. Their goal is to try and warp the streets in their own image using whichever of the two cabals is successful, though of course, the Room (pp69) has its own agenda.

NO DEAL

What if the players refuse the deal? Well, for one, whoever is going to be sacrificed as the Scion still has that hanging over their head. It's a good idea to remind the players that refusing this deal means throwing one of their own under the bus to an uncertain future. Of course, if they're enthusiastic to become a servant of the Streets, maybe that's fine by them. Or maybe the alternative of working with UMC is worse. (Which: fair.)

Thomas Campbell is not happy to be refused but he is not what you would call a heavy hitter; he may offer the below enticements to "sweeten the deal." Thomas will give them in this order, because they are increasingly inconvenient to him. (Yup. Offering the cabal jobs is the *least inconvenient*.)

- He will offer jobs to the entire cabal working for Universal Motors to modernize Detroit's--and hopefully eventually the United States'---transit system. Remind the players that half of them are homeless. Remind the players *how much this sucks for them*. The Salesman cannot coerce them,

and refusing this deal does not cause a *unnatural* stress check, but it does cause a mundane *Helplessness* rank 3 stress check for Lee and Latisha as they watch the promise of three square meals a day and a steady roof over their head fly away for a vague, distant promise of a "better Detroit" that may never materialize, and will only do so at the cost of one of their cabalmates' sanity.

- He will tell them the location of the Motown Breakers home base. It is the Fortress Burger on Woodward ave, a popular haunt among drag racers in Detroit. The cabal will almost certainly meet here before going to Black Bottom and they could use it as an opportunity to trap them and prevent them from dumping charges.
- He will send the cops to protect them from the rival cabal, the Motown Breakers, while they drop a charge at Michigan Central Station.

If the players still refuse, that's fine. Thomas Campbell will walk away and let them go on with their day. He will take the following actions, however:

- He will offer the same deal to the Motown Breakers. If the Breakers are NPCs, they automatically accept the deal. (Which I am sure will give your players a lovely post-hoc rationalization for why they are Bad People who deserve to lose.) *This gives the Breakers basically a free and easy pass to Michigan Central Station.* Which matters because
- The Big Three and UMC in particular will now be watching Michigan Central Station and the section of the 375 once known as Black Bottom like a hawk. Security details and/or cops will be lurking around these areas, which the players will now have to avoid and the Breakers will not.

The Salesman will not directly inflict violence on the cabal if they refuse his deal. The whole point of the Salesman's second channel is that his deal has to be freely accepted. Tonally, the point of the Salesman deal is to ask your players if they're willing to sell out their vision of an inclusive Detroit *just a little* to guarantee themselves a life of comparative comfort. That's a position that the marginalized are frequently put in, and frankly, I can't say as I blame them for doing it. Living on the edge *sucks*.

3. GETTING THE DROP ON 'EM: BEFORE 10AM (pp46)

AFTER 10 AM:

1. THE COPS (pp43)
2. GET IN LINE: AFTER 10AM (pp47)
3. DEPARTURES: THE CHARGE DROP (pp48)

OUTSIDE THE STATION

Michigan Central Station is a beautiful beaux-arts building abandoned in 1988, when the last trains pulled out of the station in Detroit. Their tracks remain, and many car companies have discussed using the historic landmark as a central office building, though none of them have taken the plunge.

Although the building is abandoned, it is periodically watched by police cars as it's a popular site for photographers, graffiti artists and looky-loos.

THE COPS

If the cabal arrives before 10AM, there's only one cop (pp35) car outside, which is simply monitoring the property on behalf of UMC. If the players can sneak past the cop car, they are scot-free, but if a police officer spots them, he will alert the rival cabal.

If the PC cabal arrives after 10AM on Saturday, and they *did not* accept Thomas Campbell's deal, there are four cop cars parked in front of Michigan Central Station. If the players drive up to the Station, the cop cars will turn on their lights and sirens and, if given the opportunity, tell the players that access to Central Station is restricted and they are not allowed on site. They may also ask for the players' IDs. Fighting the cops is probably not a super great idea, but if the players choose to do so, you can use the stats for four Beat Cops per pp68. It may be a better idea for the players to try and sneak around them, and if they're in a mindset where they think force is the go-to solution to their problems, you may want to remind them force is exceedingly deadly in this game.

ROLL	RESULTS
1-25	The crowd is definitely confused and disoriented, looking around and staring dumbstruck at the weirdness around them. But they aren't violent.
26-50	Everyone who isn't already injured to weird supernatural shit runs away. Add the dice rolled together: That's how many people are seriously injured as panicked humans run out of the area from a failed stress check.
51+	The number rolled is how many people are seriously injured in the riot. If the riot roll is a fumble, ten people are hospitalized in the ICU and one person dies.

Pretty soon, cops will begin showing up, looking for someone to blame; if the players refused Thomas' deal during FAGE DEAL TURN (pp32), they probably already have the players in mind.

3. CENTRAL STATION

There are three major elements to the Central Station scene:

- THE COPS, if they're present (pp43)
- THE CHARGE DROP, and the effects thereof--and (pp48)
- HORIZONTAL HOSTILITY, how the two cabals react to each other and in what order. (pp46)

Whether the cabal arrives at Central Station before or after 10AM will affect the way in which these events happen. Here is the probable order of events, depending:

BEFORE 10 AM:

1. ARRIVALS (pp46)
2. DEPARTURES: THE CHARGE DROP (pp48)

Once the players have responded to the Salesman, they should probably go to bed. It's late. If the players put this off to argue about who is going to be scion, encourage them to worry about that later, since they don't have to make a decision until they actually arrive at the 375 anyway.

THE POLICE

Of the two cabals, the Urbanomancers have probably had fewer run-ins with the cops than the Motown Breakers. But both cabals are ¾ black and mostly poor, and their relationship with the police is still going to be largely negative. If the players seem too blithely unaware of this, you may want to remind them. Once the players reach Michigan Central Station, if they have decided to accept Campbell's deal, it's worth drawing attention to the police presence at Michigan Central and spending time describing the fact that they are willing to shoot down a rival cabal of mostly-black Detroiters.

As for when the players are on the receiving end of police violence, if the cops *know* they're the rival cabal they will not pull any punches. If you think it's realistic, you can have the police try to arrest the cabalmates, but it's just as likely they'll shoot first and ask questions later. Because they can--and they know they'll get away with it. If the players do surrender to the cops and you think it's realistic that they'll arrest them instead of shooting, the players will probably go straight to the local jail for at least 24 hours. Because this is a competition and losing too much time is a fail state for the cabal, you should probably consider arrest game over for any PC that this happens to.

It's not necessary (or a good idea) to role-play the cops saying overtly racist shit. You can gloss over/veil this if you want, but more likely, some of the cops probably are black, many of them may worry about being on camera, and they don't need to say overtly racist things to be racist, because they have all the power in this situation.

THE CHARGE DROP

When the players decide to drop their charge at the Michigan Theater, the secluded nature of the location and the personal resonance of the place mean that the effects are overwhelmingly positive. In other words--this one is a gimmie. The beautiful Rococo-esque ceilings of the theater flare black to life in vivid color. Below them, a permanent skate park pops up around the players and although no skaters are visible, the sounds of their wheels hitting the pavement echo through the garage. From nowhere, Detroit-style, funk-inflected techno blares over the speakers.

The moment after this first charge is dropped feels jubilant and safe, a promise of a better world. Fade to black, and ask the PCs where they will drop their second charge: Eastern Market, Central Station--or, if you are comfortable, an alternative location.

Once the first charge has been laid, the players must now lay a second elsewhere. Remind them that the cabal has floated two locations: Eastern Market (pp37) and Michigan Central Station (pp42). If you are comfortable, the cabal can also brainstorm alternative locations as well (see: OTHER POSSIBILITIES FOR THE BLOCK BUSTERS pp36.)

OTHER POSSIBILITIES FOR THE BLOCK BUSTERS

It's possible the players will ignore the convenient plot coupon you've given them and get their own ideas about where they'd like to dump the charge. As long as you feel comfortable improvising, I think this is fine to give the one-shot a bit more of an open world feel. Here are some potential locations the players might cook up:

- **THE MOTOWN MUSEUM** - Berry Gordy Jr.'s house and former studio, the literal birthplace of Motown, is one of the most important Detroit cultural touchstones that is not car-related.
- **BELLE ISLE PARK** - One of the largest city parks in the United States at over 900 acres, designed by Olmstead, Belle Isle Park is a potent symbol of urban public works. The iconic, lion-filled James Scott Memorial fountain is an especially good site for a charge.
- **AN URBAN GARDEN** - There are several real-life Detroit urban gardens you can google, or just make one up. It's important to note that there's an emerging divide between Urban Detroit gardens made by and for the working-class, largely black folks who live there and more recent gardens made to "pretty up" vacant property in the city for downtown restaurants. The most potent sites have organic (haha) connections to black leftism--run or founded by former members of the Black Panthers or Draft Revolutionary Union Movement.

LATISHA SMITH'S VISION

A market stall suddenly comes in front of Latisha's vision, with a display of fresh vegetables and produce and their prices lovingly rendered in her handwriting. The prices on the signs reflect the hard work and care a gardener puts into a small farm, and the banner above her market has a beautiful photographic rendering of her working farm pieced together from what were once vacant Detroit lots.

A small child walks up to Latisha's stall and asks, "How much do these tomatoes cost?" If Latisha says they are free or gives them to her for nothing, the market stall rots and dissolves around her. If she says the price on the sign, which is a dollar apiece, the child disappears. A fat wad of cash is in Latisha's hands.

RACHEL BERNSTEIN'S VISION

Rachel walks a few steps forward to watch a man arguing with a younger white lady. They're both dressed in 1970s era clothes, but the young white woman wears bell bottoms and a blazer and the black man is dressed in straight leg pants and a collared cotton shirt with a jean jacket.

"If you think you can quote a little Forman and Hampton at a bunch of poor honkies and it's gonna be kumbaya the next time we picket, you're even dumber than you look," the man in the jean jacket says. "How are you going to ground your principles in the world we're actually living in?" When Rachel first moved to Detroit, what about her principles didn't live up to her actions?

...AND WHAT HAPPENS WHEN YOU DO

Don't let players linger in their vision too long--this is more of a snapshot of how they're embodying their character's relationship with Detroit than an extended scene. Once they've had a reaction, even if they don't have a clear answer to the question, snap back to the here and now where Eastern Market has become a cacophony of voices that weren't there before. The temperature fluctuates wildly on whichever shed the players are present at, blisteringly summer-hot one minute with summer produce and January cold with nothing but squash and crafts the other. At this point, you should make a riot roll for the normies at the market.

DUMPING THE CHARGE

Regardless of where the players dump the charge in Eastern Market, it will trigger a significant phenomena. At first, there will be a powerful ambient fizziness in the area, similar to how you feel on a runner's high or pleasantly buzzed. If the players have dropped the charge on the Site of Shed 1, the ghost of Shed 1 rises into the air and the chatter of long-dead market sellers can be heard. People and stands through the rest of the market are teleported to the site of Shed 1, or, if the charge is dropped into another shed, all of the market stands appear to age to 19th century versions of themselves.

Any player that drops a charge will see a vision.

LEE SHERMAN'S VISION

Lee Sherman sees himself back at the till in his Hardware Store in Brightmoor. There is a crew of young teens making a racket, bumming around, and bogarting all the popcorn. A coworker speaks up behind Lee. "I don't know why you let them hang out here," she says disapprovingly. "You outta kick them out--all they do is make a scene, chase out business and probably shoplift besides." You suspect she's right, but you wonder why they come in here day after day. One of the boys in a neon hoodie and beat-up nikes is always the first to show up after school and the last of the crew to leave. How did you handle this? What was a negative repercussion of what you chose to do?

DARIUS ANDERSON'S VISION

Darius Anderson's view of Eastern Market dissolves and he rides one of the brand new Detroit Streetcars running through Midtown Detroit. He is in front of a switch. The Trolley is about to run over a demonstration of mostly black, working class-Detroiters protesting the People Mover. If he pulls the switch, the People Mover will run over a single kid on another track instead. After Darius stares for a while, he realizes it's him on the tracks--oblivious, talking on his cell phone. What does he do?

2: BUSTERS: EASTERN MARKET



Assuming the Block Busters move to dump the next charge, The existing location they have been contemplating is Eastern Market, the biggest outdoor market in the United States. It has been running consistently since 1841--it's a Detroit fixture and, despite it's modern concessions to things like parking garages and lots, people still move through Eastern Market primarily on foot. The market runs all day on Saturday, and this is the time when dropping a charge is most symbolically potent.

Eastern market has five Sheds (Shed 1 no longer stands), and despite the game being set in the dead of winter in the balmy city of Detroit, the market is open year-round. Yes, in all of the sheds. Sheds 2, 3 and 5 are sturdy, tall structures made of brick, each of them labeled with a bright neon sign atop the roof. But only Shed 2 has the distinctive double arches and granite sign proudly emblazoned in serifed font with "EASTERN MARKET."

Shed 2 of Eastern Market was built in 1898 to accommodate vendors in the market, and it is the oldest standing shed. Shed 1 was built in 1891 and was demolished in 1967 to make space for an Expressway. All of the sheds are symbolically potent enough to make a good location to dump a charge, but ironically it is the parking

lot--the site of the first shed of the largest market in the US that was demolished for a freeway--that is the most symbolically potent. Shed 2 is also a strong contender.

When the players arrive on-site in Eastern market, an eccentric-looking elderly woman with a wavy bob in a bright red dress approaches the cabal. Rachel Bernstein recognizes her as Diane, a fellow dabbler in the occult underground who deals in vintage hardware and fixtures for historic buildings (and keeps the most interesting stuff for herself.) What Rachel does not know is that she is also an agent of the Streets.

She introduces herself and asks the cabal to do her a favor: find the most valuable item in Eastern Market, and she will tell them the best location in Eastern Market to drop their second charge. Lee Sherman and Rachel Bernstein have the channel *Streetwise*, but you may remind the players that any of them can cast this channel if they wish to spend the charges.

The Agent will choose the scion based on what they bring back, which is different for each player. (If the players have already chosen a scion, you can skip this part. Or, maybe you like to sow division and chaos among your PCs. I'm not your boss.) If the players use any of their identities or relationships *and* the *Streetwise* channel, you should give them an appropriate shift on their *Streetwise* roll:

- A simple success should give the character a 10% shift.
- A matched success should give the character 20% shift.
- A critical should give the character an automatic matched success on their *Streetwise* check.

Make sure the player role-plays or narratively justifies the use of their other identity or relationship! The players may also work collectively to find a single item in Eastern Market together--this is totally fine, but whoever makes the final roll that finds the most valuable item in Eastern Market will be marked by the agent as the scion.

If the players would like to come up with an item on their own, this should be encouraged! The items below are suggestions for successful players that don't have ideas of their own, or for whom inventing something will be a chore and not a fun

creative exercise. The antiques should all be around \$50. The spinach is around \$5/lb.

Rachel Bernstein	A piece of the Michigan Theater that has been lost to time, found at an antiques shed.
Latisha Smith	The only local spinach in the market. (It's grown in a high tunnel greenhouse in Michigan, if a player asks.)
Darius Anderson	An old chair from a 19th century Detroit Streetcar.
Lee Sherman	The sign from his old hardware store. Probably give him a moment, as it's likely to be emotional.

When they return to Diane with the item, she will put her hands on the shoulders of the player with the best roll, say "You are Motown's chosen," then shake her head as if coming out of a trance. If the players cross-examine her about what this means or who she is, she has no memory of saying this and begins to lead them to the site of Shed 1.

If *all of the players fail*, they are on their own on where to drop the charge, and Diane will not pick a scion.

If the players succeed at Diane's task, she will lead them to the center of the parking lot where Shed 1 once stood and explain that it was the site of the original Eastern Market, before it was leveled for an expressway--a site that symbolizes Detroit's past as bustling urban center, the fact that that urban center was paved away for its automobiles, and the open question mark of which represents its future--will the parking lot become a bustling site of urban activity again, or continue to represent Detroit's reliance on cars?

WE HAVE QUESTIONS

Players may cross-examine Diane for information about the Motown Breakers, the ritual, and the Streets of Motown. Diane will answer any of their questions she'd know the answers to, *except for* information on the Room's Trial and any information that would *actively sabotage* the Motown Breaker's chances of success. Information on their goals or cabal is okay, but she won't tell the Busters their location or plans.